The Essential South Indian Cookbook

A Culinary Journey Into South Indian Cuisine & Culture

Srividhya Gopalakrishnan

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Interior and Cover Designer: Michael Cook
Art Producer: Sue Bischofberger
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ISBN: Print 978-1-64152-709-5 | eBook 978-1-64152-710-1

To my family

Contents

Introduction

CHAPTER 1

Beyond Naan

CHAPTER 2

Kitchen Essentials

CHAPTER 3

Breakfast

Idli (Savory Rice Cakes)
Dosai (Savory Rice Crêpes)
Upma (Savory Semolina Porridge)
Neer Dosa (Soft and Lacy Rice Crêpes)
Pesarattu (Green Mung Bean Crêpes)
Puttu (Steamed Rice Cakes Layered with Coconut)
Appam (Soft Rice Pancakes)
Adai (Mixed Lentil Pancakes)
Ragi Mudde (Savory Finger Millet Balls)
Akki Roti (Rice Flour Flatbread)

CHAPTER 4

Rice and Grains

Bisi Bele Bath (Rice and Lentils Dish)
Pulihora (Tamarind Rice)
Lemon Rice
Coconut Rice
Vangi Bath (Brinjal Rice)
Chettinadu Vegetable Biryani
Nei Choru (Ghee Rice)
Mavinakayi Chitranna (Raw Mango Rice)
Ven Pongal (Savory Rice with Split Yellow Mung Beans)
Sakkarai Pongal (Sweet Jaggery Rice)

CHAPTER 5

Chutneys and Pickles

Coconut Chutney
Onion-Tomato Chutney
Allam Pachadi (Ginger Chutney)
Cut Mango Pickles
Lemon Pickles
Curry Leaf, Mint, and Cilantro Chutney
Andhra Palli Chutney (Peanut Tamarind Chutney)
Gongura Pachadi (Sorrel Leaves Chutney)

CHAPTER 6

Snacks

Raw Banana (Plantain) Chips
Pazham Pori (Ripened Banana Fritters)
Punugulu (Deep-Fried Rice Fritters)

Ulundu Vadais (Soft Lentil Fritters)
Goli Baje (Mangalorean Soft Fritters with Yogurt)
Nippattu (Rice Crackers)
Onion and Mint Pakoda (Onion and Mint Fritters)

CHAPTER 7

Vegetable Sides and Mains

Avial (Mixed Vegetable Curry in Yogurt Sauce)
Mixed Vegetable Sambar (Mixed Vegetable Gravy)
Ridge Gourd Kootu (Ridge Gourd and Yellow Mung Bean Gravy)
Kosambari (Lentil and Vegetable Salad)
Erissery (Plantain and Yam Curry)
Cabbage Palya (Green Cabbage and Coconut Stir-Fry)
Vegetable Sagu (Mixed Vegetable Curry)
Kakarakaya Bellam Vepudu (Bitter Gourd Jaggery Stir-Fry)
Soppu Saaru (Spinach and Lentil Gravy)
Tomato Rasam (Tomato Soup)
Bangaladumpa Ullipaya Vepudu (Potato-Onion Curry)
Gutti Vankaya Koora (Stuffed Eggplant Curry)
Bendakaya Ullipaya Pulusu (Okra and Onion Tamarind Stew)

CHAPTER 8

Fish and Seafood

Meen Pollichathu (Fried Fish in Banana Leaf)
Fish Pulusu (Andhra Fish Curry)
Andhra-Style Prawn Fry
Fish Molee (Kerala-Style Fish Stew)
South Indian–Style Crab Masala
South Indian–Style Fish Fry

Kerala-Style Prawn Masala Roast
Eral Thokku (Tamil Nadu–Style Prawn Gravy)
Malabar-Style Prawn Soup
Fish Puttu (Shredded Fish Masala)

CHAPTER 9

Meat Dishes

Kodi Vepudu (Andhra Chicken Fry)
Chicken 65 (Deep-Fried Chicken Dish)
Chicken Dum Biryani
Ragu Muda Natu Kodi Pulusu (Country Chicken Curry from Andhra)
Mutton Curry
Egg Kurma (Egg Curry)
Hyderabadi-Style Kheema (Hyderabadi-Style Minced Meat)
Kori Gassi (Mangalorean Chicken Curry)
Beef Ularthiyathu (Slow-Roasted Beef)
Mutton Kola Urundai (Mutton Meat Balls)

CHAPTER 10

Sweets

Unni Appam (Sweet Banana Fritters)
Ada Pradhaman (Vegan Rice Flakes Pudding)
Saggubiyyam Payasam (Tapioca Pearls Pudding)
Rava Kesari (Thick Semolina Pudding)
Obbattu (Stuffed Sweet Flatbread with Bengal Gram)
Poornam Boorelu (Stuffed Sweet Fritters)
Gasagase Payasa (Poppy Seed Kheer)

Measurement Conversions

Acknowledgments

About the Author

Introduction

Food and cooking have always fascinated me. To understand my connection with South Indian cuisine, hop aboard a time machine and return with me to my native home, where we had no refrigerators or fancy kitchen accessories. In spite of this, my mother cooked the most delicious food!

I was born and raised in a small town in the valley of the Western Ghats mountain range, located in South Tamil Nadu. My mother's maternal family lived in Kerala, but my ancestry actually traces back to Karnataka, and the food I grew up with was an amalgamation of dishes from all these areas.

My mother was my first culinary teacher. She created lip-smacking meals with freshly ground spices and vegetables from sellers who came to our door with produce picked from their farms that morning. Everything we ate—*ghee* (clarified butter), yogurt, pickles, spice powders—was made at home from scratch. Fresh ingredients and my mom's recipes created magic. Mom's *poori* (deep-fried bread) and onion rice could quell even the worst of my tantrums.

Even though I learned most of the basics from my mom, my culinary roots go even deeper—my paternal grandfather was a restaurateur, and my maternal grandmother ran a home-based food joint, where she was the chief cook. My passions for food, cooking, and serving are part of my identity.

Anyone who assumes South Indian food is restricted to *idli* and *sambar* will be surprised by this book, which reflects the breadth of the region's culinary offerings. I've included some of my favorite recipes, like

upma, *pesarattu*, and *puttu*, along with assorted chutneys, curries, gravies, rice-based dishes, and traditional sweets.

I'm excited to share 75 of my favorite recipes. With a bit of time, patience, and passion, you can create authentic South Indian dishes that are bursting with flavor.

Let's journey to South India!

Mixed Vegetable Curry in Yogurt Sauce

CHAPTER 1

Beyond Naan

India is a melting pot of different cultures, traditions, and cuisines. There's a common misconception outside of the Indian subcontinent that Indian cuisine is all about naan, tikka masalas, and samosas. Yes, they are part of Indian cuisine—North Indian cuisine to be exact. In fact, the country's cuisine is so regional, even classifying some dishes as North Indian and others as South Indian is difficult. Every state in India has its own distinct cuisine and cooking techniques.

South Indian Cuisine

South India is a peninsula with a diverse landscape with the Bay of Bengal to the east, the Arabian Sea to the west, and the Indian Ocean to the south. Two east–west mountain ranges—Vindhya and Satpura—divide the Indian subcontinent into the Indo-Gangetic Plain of North India and the

Deccan Plateau of South India. With mountains, seas, plateaus, rivers, and fertile plains, the landscape of South India is highly varied, just like its unique dishes.

The cuisine of South India comprises the food traditions of five states —Andhra, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and Telangana—along with the union territories of Pondicherry, Lakshadweep, and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands (which are famous for their seafood). You can find Keralan influences in Lakshadweep and Tamil Nadu influences in Pondicherry. The cuisines of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands are an amalgamation of a number of regional cuisines.

South India uses millets, lentils, coconut, tamarind, fresh seasonal fruits, and vegetables extensively, but rice is the region's staple food. Plain, steamed rice is found everywhere, and it is typically served with stews, curries, and gravies made with freshly roasted and ground spices. Fragrant basmati rice is a favorite in North India, but *sona masoori*, *ponni*, and *matta* are popular in the south. These rice varieties are used boiled, par-boiled, or raw. Boiled and raw rice are used for day-to-day consumption, whereas par-boiled rice is used for making many breakfast delicacies and snacks. For biryanis, basmati, *seeraga* samba, and *kaima* rice varieties are also used.

South Indian cuisine is also known for idli, *dosa*, sambar, chutney, and filter coffee, which can differ from state to state. A Karnataka-style sambar (lentil-based stew) is different from Keralan and Tamil Nadu–style sambars, even though they all use tamarind, split pigeon peas, and vegetables. All the coastal areas are famous for their seafood, and you can find a lot of coconut-based dishes in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. Karnataka is known for sorghum and ragi-based recipes, and Andhra and Telangana are renowned for their spicy and tangy dishes.

South Indian geography is not the only influence on the cuisine. Religion and traditional Indian medicine systems such as Siddha, Ayurveda, and Unani also have a huge influence. Siddha medicine, or *citta maruthuvam*, originated in Tamil Nadu and is quite popular in the South.

The Siddhas laid the foundation for this ancient practice, which is grounded in the belief that food is medicine. Native, seasonal produce and herbs are used to create a well-balanced diet that aids digestion.

Ayurveda is another traditional Indian medicine system that is popular throughout India and around the world. Ayurveda classifies food into three categories: *Sattvic* foods, such as mild vegetarian dishes; *rajasic* foods that increase energy and serve as stimulants; and *tamasic* foods, which are mostly sedatives. A balanced diet of sattvic, tamasic, and rajasic foods is thought to help the mind, body, and soul. During festivals and on auspicious days, garlic and onion are avoided because they fall under the rajasic food category; a sattvic diet is typically followed on those days.

Unani is a traditional medicinal practice that came to India through the Mughals around the tenth century. The term *unani* is Arabic and means "Greek"; over the centuries, Unani medicine was influenced by the other Indian medicine systems.

Traditional Indian medicines utilize local, seasonal produce and rely on simple herbs and spices such as turmeric, cardamom, pepper, Indian basil, cinnamon, and cloves to cure common ailments. Every spice used in cooking is believed not only to balance flavors, but also to aid digestion.

Tamil Nadu

The Tamil region is home to one of the country's most ancient cuisines. The English word *curry* is derived from the Tamil word *kari*, meaning "sauce" or "gravy." The word *congee* is derived from the Tamil word *kanji*, meaning "gruel."

The ancient Tamilians believed that "Unave marundu, marunde unavu," or "Food is medicine, medicine is food." Ancient sages followed this popular Siddha medicine principle that uses natural foods and herbs to cure many ailments. Even though Tamil cuisine hails back to the Siddhar age (circa 9600 BCE to 5200 BCE), modern Tamil cuisine has Marathi and Nawabi influences thanks to the Maratha rulers of Tanjore

and the Nawabs of Arcot, who populated the area in the sixteenth, seventeenth, and eighteenth centuries.

The story of the origin of *sambar*—the quintessential dish of Tamil Nadu—is quite interesting. According to legend, when Tanjore was under Maratha rule in the seventeenth century, Sambaji, eldest son of the great ruler Shivaji, tried to prepare *dal* (lentil curry) but couldn't find *kokum* (dry sour fruit). To add the required sour taste, he used tamarind, along with split pigeon peas and vegetables, to make the dal. The resulting dish, *sambhar* or sambar, reflects the name of its creator, Sambaji. Today, you can find at least 50 varieties of sambar in South India.

The Nawabs ruled the region between the eastern and western mountain ranges. They introduced biryani, made with fragrant seeraga samba rice, and *ambur biryani* was born. The dish would become famous across the country.

Regions within the state of Tamil Nadu, such as Kongunadu, Nanjilnadu, Madurai, and Chettinad, also have distinct native recipes. Some popular dishes of the Kongunadu region are *kollu masiyal* (horse gram lentils curry), and the humble rice and lentils dish known as *arisi paruppu sadam*. Nanjilnadu is the southern coastal region of Tamil Nadu and is popular for its seafood delicacies. It is also influenced by Kerala cuisine, given its proximity to that state. Madurai is known for its soft and fluffy idlis, flaky *parottas*, and mutton *dosas* (crêpes). Chettinad dishes are known for their spices, including black stone flower, mace, and kapok buds, which add kick as well as flavor. Chettinad cuisine is also famous for its meat curries and biryanis, in addition to *paniyarams* (steamed rice and lentil dumplings).

Tamil meals are called *saapadu* and are traditionally served on a banana leaf. A typical vegetarian meal consists of rice accompanied by *sambar* (lentil-based stew), *rasam* (thin lentil or non-lentil–based soup), a dry vegetable curry called *porial*, and a gravy vegetable curry or *kootu*. Add *payasam* (sweet pudding), salads, *pachadis* (yogurt-based relishes), mixed rice, and chutneys for an elaborate and delicious meal.

Telangana and Andhra

Historically known as the "rice bowl of India," the East Godavari region of Andhra Pradesh is the largest producer of rice and red chiles. The new state of Telangana was created on June 2, 2014, from the northwestern portion of Andhra Pradesh.

Telugu cuisine is a flavorful blend of cuisines from Telangana and two other regions, Coastal Andhra and Rayalaseema. Its use of red chiles makes Telugu cuisine one of the world's richest and spiciest. Both vegetarian and nonvegetarian dishes are staples of Telugu kitchens. *Bhojanam* is the traditional meal served in Andhra, and Telangana is the home of spicy hot pickles, particularly the *gongura*, which embody the cultural identity of Telugu cuisine.

Telangana is the leading producer of millet in India, and the state is known for its millet- and *roti*-based (unleavened bread) dishes. *Jowar* and *bajra* feature prominently in local recipes. Telugu cuisine is similar in many ways to the cuisines of neighboring states Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, and Karnataka.

Hyderabad is the capital city of both Andhra and Telangana. The Hyderabadi kitchen often follows the cooking style known as Deccan cuisine. In the seventeenth century the Nizams, or rulers, of Hyderabad introduced the cuisine, which is an amalgamation of Mughal, Turkish, and Arabic dishes combined with native Telugu and Marathi elements. Hyderabadi *dum biryani* is famous worldwide.

The Krishna and Godavari delta regions dominate Coastal Andhra, where rice, dal, and seafood are staples. The dishes of Rayalaseema, the southern region of Andhra, are known for their liberal use of red chile powder and for the millets *ragi* and *jowar*. Jowar roti (sorghum roti) and *bajra* roti (pearl millet roti) are quite famous in the region.

Idli and dosa are quite popular in Andhra, which is also the home of *pesarattu*—a moong dal–based savory crêpe usually served with ginger chutney. Telugu cuisine has a range of snacks and sweets, such as *garelu*

(savory lentil fritters), *punugulu* (deep-fried rice fritters), *laddu* (sweet balls), *boondhi* (savory chickpea flour snacks), *gavvulu* (sweet jaggery shells), and *kesari* (sweet semolina porridge).

Kerala

The state of Kerala, known regionally as "God's own country" and the land of spices, is famous for its greenery, backwaters, boathouses, tea and cardamom plantations, beautiful beaches, and Arya Vaidya Salas (Ayurveda treatment centers).

Kerala cuisine features vegetarian and nonvegetarian dishes and has an impressive range of culinary influences. In the Middle Ages, Greek, Roman, Chinese, Portuguese, Arab, and Dutch traders made their way to the port towns of Kerala to buy pepper, cardamom, cloves, and other spices. Keralites love their parboiled red rice, popularly known as the Kerala matta rice, which is usually served with curries. Along with rice, tapioca (or *kappa* in the Malayalam language spoken in Kerala), and congee, (*kanji*) are also popular.

When we think about South Indian breakfast, idli or dosa typically come to mind. But Kerala cuisine offers many delicious vegetarian breakfast dishes that are relatively uncommon outside the state. Dishes such as *idiyappam* (string hoppers) and *appam* (fluffy, crisp-edged pancakes) are known outside of the region, but *puttu*, a steamed dish made of rice powder and shredded coconut, is a popular breakfast dish little known outside Kerala.

Muslims and Syrian Christians contributed dishes and cooking techniques to Kerala cuisine, particularly its nonvegetarian fare. Kerala is famous for its beef curry, chicken stew, and stir-fries, which are eaten with rice or flatbread-like *chapati* (made with wheat flour) or parotta (flaky flatbread made with all-purpose flour).

No description of Kerala cuisine would be complete without mentioning the feasts for the Onam and Onam Sadya festivals. Onam is

the annual Hindu festival celebrating the Vamana avatar of Lord Vishnu and the homecoming of the emperor Mahabali, the grandson of King Prahalada. The last day of Onam is celebrated with a delicious vegetarian feast called *onasadya*. Onam Sadya is celebrated with a wide variety of dishes (typically 15 to 30) loaded with veggies and coconut and traditionally served on banana leaves.

Kerala is known for its warm desserts called *pradhaman*, which are similar to the payasam or *kheer* of Tamil Nadu. You can find a lot of fruit-based vegan kheers with coconut milk and jaggery, along with gluten-free kheers and rice pasta.

Karnataka

With a mix of rice and millet recipes, the cuisine of the state of Karnataka is said to be one of the oldest in the country—and one of the most diverse due to the influence of its neighboring South Indian states and the west-central state of Maharashtra.

Some Karnataka recipes are famous worldwide. They include masala dosa (stuffed savory crêpes with potato curry), *bisibelebaath* (spicy lentil rice), *kesari baath* (sweet semolina pudding), *khara baath* (spicy semolina pudding), and *mysore pak* (chickpea flour and jaggery fudge). By contrast, some Karnataka breakfast recipes, such as ragi *mudde* (finger millet balls) and *akki roti* (flatbread made with rice flour), are hard to find outside the region.

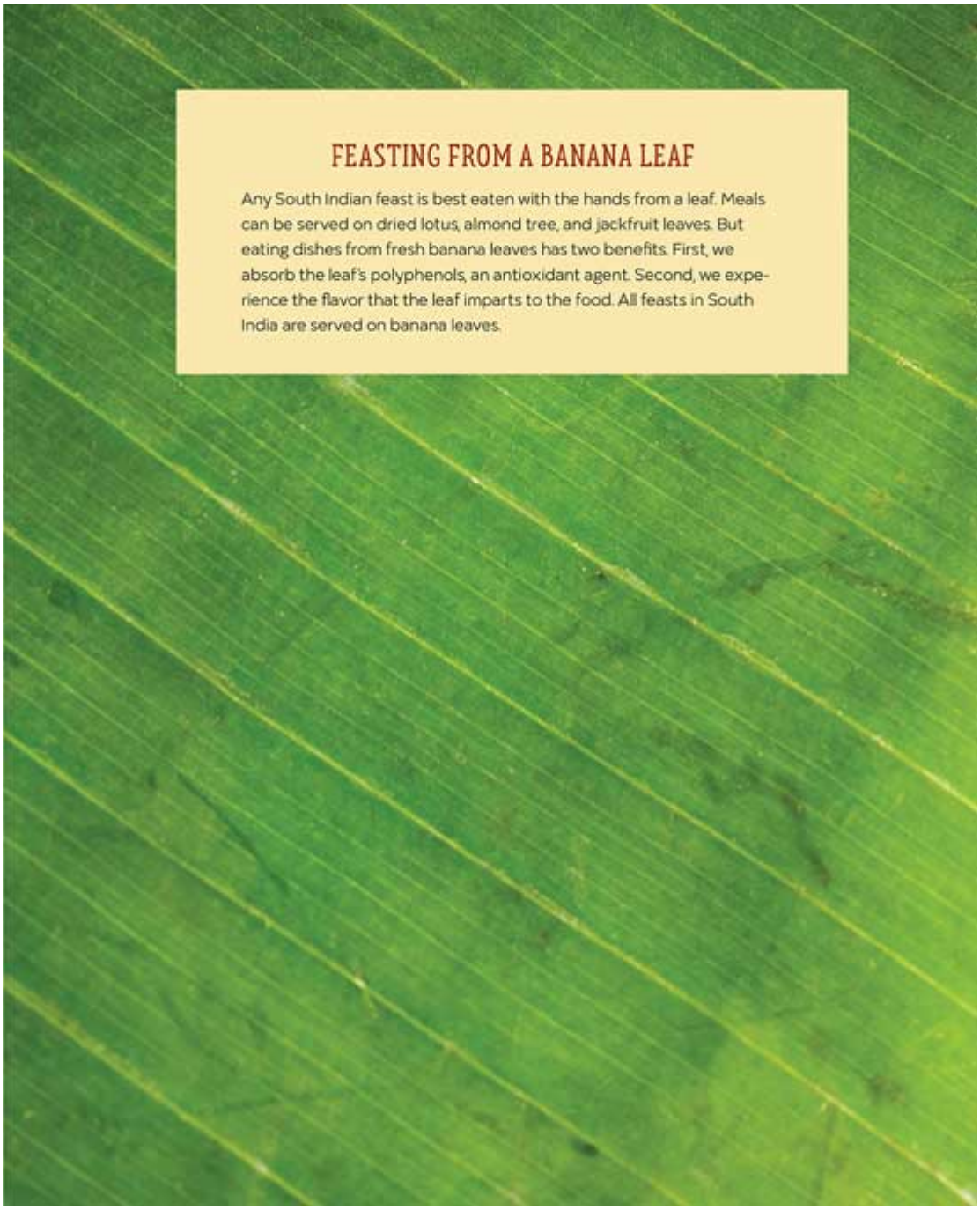
Like other South Indian states, Karnataka has regional specialties. Rice and jowar are popular in north Karnataka; rice and ragi, in south Karnataka. North Karnataka dishes are mostly vegetarian. Jowar rotis and wheat rotis are quite popular, and they are served with spicy curries like stuffed brinjals and spinach curries. Steamed rice and ragi balls are also staples of South Karnataka, and the rice is usually served with sambar, *saaru* (think lentil soup), dry curries, called *palya*, and salads known as *kosambari*.

In the north Canara region—also known as Malenadu, or the land of mountains—dishes with bamboo shoots and colocasia leaves are popular. The region's cuisine is influenced by both Kodagu and Mangalorean cuisines. The Coorg district of Karnataka has its own cuisine called *kodagu,* or corgi, cuisine. It is known for its meat dishes, including chicken, pork, and mutton curries.

Navayath, the Indian Muslim community in northern Karnataka, is known for meat-based dishes and biryanis. The Mangalorean cuisine of coastal Karnataka is known for its seafood delicacies and its extensive use of coconut, coconut oil, and curry leaves. *Kori gassi,* a chicken curry, and *yeti gassi,* a prawn curry, are favorite dishes.

Whereas the Mangalore region is known for its nonvegetarian dishes, neighboring Udupi's reputation is for its vegetarian-only dishes. The cuisine takes its name from the city Udupi, which is on the southwest coast of the Karnataka. Udupi cuisine adheres to Sattvic food principles, and its origins are in the Tulu Ashta Mathas (Hindu monasteries) that were founded by Madhvacharya.

Filter coffee, or *kaapi,* is a favorite in all South Indian states, but it is the cultural identity of Karnataka, which accounts for more than 70 percent of India's coffee production. Monsoons have helped create excellent coffee-growing conditions in the Coorg/Kodagu. Coorg coffee plantations and resorts have become popular tourism areas.



FEASTING FROM A BANANA LEAF

Any South Indian feast is best eaten with the hands from a leaf. Meals can be served on dried lotus, almond tree, and jackfruit leaves. But eating dishes from fresh banana leaves has two benefits. First, we absorb the leaf's polyphenols, an antioxidant agent. Second, we experience the flavor that the leaf imparts to the food. All feasts in South India are served on banana leaves.

CHAPTER 2

Kitchen Essentials

If you ask me to choose one piece of cookware I can't live without, I would say an idli steamer. For me, it's as essential as knives, cutting boards, measuring cups, spatulas, and spoons when I prepare South Indian recipes. Soapstone vessels, clay pots, cast iron, and brass pots and pans were used for South Indian cooking in ancient times, and their use is being revived in South India. But you don't need this traditional cookware to start cooking South Indian recipes—you can easily start with the saucepans and pots you already have.

A wide range of spices are used in South Indian cooking. This book includes recipes for most of the custom spice powders such as *vangi bath* spice powder, sambar powder, and rasam powder. A fair number of recipes call for ground coriander, Indian red chile powder, and ground

turmeric, all of which you can find in most grocery stores.

In this chapter, I discuss the essential cookware and spices used in South Indian cooking.

Cookware

You can whip up many a delicious South Indian feast with just two saucepans and one frying pan, but there are some specialty cookware and utensils that can be helpful, especially when making some of the breakfast and snack recipes (I do include alternative ways of cooking those dishes).

Saucepans: A medium saucepan will prepare enough of any South Indian gravy or curry for four or more people. I always prefer stainless steel cookware, and I try to stay away from nonstick cookware.

Kadai | Frying Pan: A *kadai* is an Indian wok. This thick, deep cooking pot with a flat base is ideal for deep-frying snacks likes *appalam/papad*, poori, *vada*, and *bajji*. You don't need to limit your kadai to frying; you can also use it to make gravies and stir-fries.

Spice Rack: Indian cooking uses a wide range of spice powders and whole spices. You need a proper spice rack or glass jars with tight lids to store the spices and masalas.

Pressure Cooker: Almost every Indian kitchen has a pressure cooker. I cannot imagine my life without one. From cooking rice and lentils to steaming vegetables, a pressure cooker reduces the time it takes to prepare a recipe and results in perfectly cooked food with great texture. You can find an Indian-style pressure cooker online. A 2- or 4-liter pressure cooker would suffice, but an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, can be used. For the recipes that call for pressure cooking or steaming, I provide instructions for how to use an electric pressure cooker.

Blender: For chutneys and freshly ground pastes with coconut you need a good blender. I use my coffee grinder to make small quantities of wet and

dry masalas. For making idli and dosa batter, a good blender makes all the difference. Traditionally the idli and dosa batters are prepared in a stone grinder, but a blender works perfectly well.

Idli Racks | Idli Steamer: Idli racks are stainless steel trays with four concave depressions where the idli batter is poured. The trays are then stacked and placed inside a steamer or pressure cooker. These racks are also used for cooking *kozhukattai* (sweet dumplings) and other delicacies. Until you're ready to invest in idli racks, use small stainless bowls. You can also use a wide bowl; simply cut the idli into small pieces after steaming.

Dosa Tawa | Griddle: A round griddle is best for making dosa (savory crêpes). Any pre-seasoned cast iron griddle or electric griddle used to make pancakes, crêpes, and quesadillas can be used for making dosa and flatbreads—be it the sweet *obbattu* or the *akki* roti.

Murukku Press: This is also known as *chakli* press. Traditionally made of brass, the press is now commonly made of stainless steel. It has two cylinders. One is a hollow cylinder you fill with dough. The other is a solid cylinder you slide into the hollow cylinder to press the dough out in different shapes, which are then fried. Rotating murukku presses are now available and they are very convenient.

Puttu Steamer: This steamer for making the special puttu of Kerala consists of a pot in which water is added for steaming. Attached to the pot is a cylinder filled with rice flour and coconut. The steam from the pot cooks the puttu. Puttu makers are available in cookware stores and online. You also can steam the puttu in your electric or stovetop pressure cooker, but you won't get the cylindrical puttu shape.

Paniyaram Pan: Paniyaram, a dough made of black lentils and rice, has its own special pan. The paniyaram, or *appe*, pan has molds for steaming the dough. You can use it to make the Kerala sweets unni appams as well as shallow-fried snacks.

Perforated Ladles and Slotted Spoons: A slotted spoon or perforated ladle is a must for deep-frying.

Coconut Scraper: Coconut scrapers (graters) are an integral part of the South Indian kitchen, where fresh coconut is used to make masalas, stir-fries, and chutneys. That said, you can use shredded coconut, found in the frozen or baking aisles of most supermarkets. It works fine for almost all the recipes here that call for coconut.

Coffee Filter: My morning always begins with a cup of filtered coffee. Indian coffee filters differ slightly from filters you find in the West. Brass or stainless steel coffee filters and electric filters work well. My personal favorite is a stainless steel filter.

ELECTRIC PRESSURE COOKER TIP

Rice is the staple of South Indian meals. My grandmother used to cook rice using the open pot method. But with the invention of pressure cookers and electric pressure cookers like the Instant Pot®, cooking rice is quite easy. I like the Instant Pot® because it is energy efficient and because it reduces cooking time. I use my Instant Pot® just about every day to cook rice, lentils, and legumes. I prefer the Rice preset for my South Indian plain steamed rice, and I use the Bean/Chili preset for all lentils, such as split pigeon peas, mung beans, and Bengal gram. For legumes, I use the Manual or Pressure Cook mode and set the time manually. The cooking time depends on the quality of the legumes and whether you have pre-soaked them.

Pantry Staples

Rice, legumes, semolina, vermicelli, fresh fruits and vegetables, and cooking oil are essentials in the South Indian kitchen.

Rice

Different varieties of rice are used in South Indian cooking. Kerala locals prefer matta rice; residents of other South Indian states prefer either raw rice or parboiled rice. Basmati is used only for biryanis, which can also be made with fragrant varieties like seeraga samba and kaima. For everyday cooking, a short-grain rice is the go-to. I recommend short-grained raw or parboiled sona masoori or ponni or any samba variety, which you can use for all South Indian rice dishes, including biryanis. For idli and dosa, you need idli rice.

Legumes

The four main lentils used in everyday South Indian cooking are the split pigeon peas (toor dal), Bengal gram (chana dal, or the desi split chickpeas), split yellow mung beans (moong dal), and husked whole black lentils (urad dal). Husked whole black lentils are mainly used to prepare idli and dosa, but they can be used to make chutneys to accompany Bengal gram. Split pigeon peas are the key ingredient in *sambar* and rasam, and split yellow mung beans are used to make savory *pongal* and gravies and curries.

Fried gram or roasted gram is the roasted split chana dal. It is widely used in South Indian cooking, especially in freshly ground masalas and chutneys. It's a great snack on its own, and it's the key ingredient in coconut chutney.

Stock up on husked whole black lentils, green mung beans, and other legumes. You can always add some beans and legumes to your gravy curries for an extra serving of plant-based protein.

Semolina and Vermicelli

Semolina and vermicelli are widely used for savory and sweet dishes. These two ingredients come in handy for breakfast and snack recipes. Semolina, or *rava* as it is known in South India, is a granulated and refined whole-wheat grain. I prefer roasted and coarse varieties for both sweet and savory dishes. Try a roasted upma mix, which is available in all Indian grocery stores. Vermicelli, or *semiya*, is the thinner version of pasta. Like rava, roasted vermicelli is available in Indian groceries. Use it to make upma or kheer (sweet pudding).

Fruits and Vegetables

South Indian dishes call for fresh seasonal fruits and vegetables. Banana and jackfruit are commonly used fruits. Every South Indian cuisine has its regional-specific vegetables, like ash gourd, snake gourd, ridge gourd, bitter melon, and tubers. You can find most of these vegetables, including curry leaves, in Indian or Asian grocery stores. Some of the rare finds are available in the frozen aisle. I usually stock up on frozen coconut and *moringa* pods or drumsticks.

Cooking Oils

Four primary fats are used in South Indian cooking: clarified butter or ghee, coconut oil, sesame oil, and any neutral oil such as vegetable oil, corn oil, or sunflower oil. I love using avocado oil for South Indian cooking. You can buy butter and make your own ghee, or you can buy ghee from the store. Ghee, coconut oil, and sesame oil are mainly used for tempering; sesame oil is used for making pickles. I prefer a neutral oil with a high smoke point for frying, but you can use coconut oil. I recommend stocking up on ghee and either coconut or another neutral oil.

Essential Spices

South Indian cooking is all about the spices. Here are some of the essential spices and spice powders used for tempering and making curry pastes.

Black Mustard Seeds: These tiny, pungent, and slightly bitter seeds are widely used for dal, sambar, stir-fries, and curries. Roasted and ground mustard seeds are also added to pickles. You can find both yellow and black mustard seeds in most supermarkets, but black mustard seeds are more commonly used in South Indian cooking.

Cumin Seeds: I love cumin seeds. Seasoning curries and stir-fries with cumin seeds adds a whole new flavor profile. A key tempering ingredient, cumin seeds are also used for making rasam spice powder, sambar powder, and fresh masalas.

Whole Peppercorns: Many curry pastes call for curry leaves and whole peppercorns. Peppercorns are occasionally used for tempering, for example, in recipes like savory Ven Pongal.

Fenugreek Seeds: These tiny golden-yellow seeds are bitter, but they add a fantastic flavor profile to any dish. Like mustard seeds, they are used in pickles and also for tempering, especially in sambar. Many of this book's recipes call for a small number of fenugreek seeds, for which there is no exact substitute. If you can't source them, you can skip them. The flavor of your dish will not drastically differ as a result.

Coriander Seeds: Coriander seeds are used for making sambar and rasam spice powders and Mangalorean curries. I like to dry-roast the seeds and grind them to make fresh coriander powder.

Dried Red Chiles: Dried red chiles are the primary spice agent used in South Indian kitchens. Varieties include the Guntur red chiles (one of my

favorites) from Andhra, Ramnad round chiles from Tamil Nadu, and a shrunken type called *byadgi* from Karnataka. I also like the byadgi variety because it is mild and yields a vibrant red color when used in pastes, stir-fries, and chutneys.

Cardamom: North Indian cuisine uses both black and green cardamom. South Indian cuisine primarily uses green cardamom for kormas and biryanis, for nonvegetarian gravies, and desserts. Payasam (kheer, or puddings) are flavored with crushed green cardamom.

Cloves: Together with crushed green cardamom, cloves are an integral part of South Indian desserts, korma and biryanis, and masala chai. A small amount goes a long way; make sure you store this spice in an airtight container to preserve its fragrance and flavor.

Cinnamon: Surprisingly, cinnamon is not used in South Indian dessert recipes. It is mainly used for making curry pastes. Cinnamon barks are more prevalent in India than cinnamon sticks. You can use either the flat barks or the round sticks in this book's recipes.

Fennel Seeds: Fragrant and sweet fennel seeds are used as mouth fresheners as well as in tempering and curry preparations. Be careful when tempering fennel seeds; browned fennel seeds taste bitter, and they spoil the dish.

Sesame Seeds: Both white and black sesame seeds are used in South Indian cooking. Sesame seed *ladoo* is a favorite dessert. Sesame seed powders are used extensively in the dishes of Andhra, Telangana, and Karnataka. You can use either white or black sesame seeds. You don't need to stock up on both.

Poppy Seeds: Nutty-flavored white poppy seeds are used for enriching curries. They add a creaminess to dishes. Poppy seed kheer is quite popular in Karnataka.

Tamarind: Most South Indian dishes have tamarind as their base. In the United States, you can get (almost) seedless tamarind blocks and tamarind paste. You can substitute tamarind paste for the block tamarind in a recipe, or vice versa, depending on the age of the tamarind and brand. Some store-bought pastes are sweet, and some are sour, so determining amounts is really a personal preference. A marble-size tamarind block equals 2 teaspoons of tamarind paste. If you are working with tamarind blocks, you'll need to extract the tamarind pulp. Soak the blocks in boiling water, stirring occasionally, for at least 30 minutes. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes as well. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside until needed.

Asafoetida: Asafoetida is a dried latex with a pungent smell that aids digestion. Many home remedies use asafoetida. If you follow a gluten-free diet, skip asafoetida. You can use a mix of onion and garlic powder instead.

Ground Turmeric: Indian curries are incomplete without ground turmeric. This superfood adds not only flavor but gives dishes a vibrant yellow color, and is often used as an antiseptic. Many recipes call for turmeric and pepper because they help kill bacteria that may be found on greens like spinach.

Red Chile Powder: This book's recipes mostly call for freshly made ground masalas, but some dishes use red chile powder. You can purchase the powder, or you can dry-roast dried red chiles and pulse them in a grinder.

Ground Coriander: Some curries and gravies call for ground coriander. Buy the powder or dry-roast and grind coriander seeds.

Garam Masala: A good garam masala elevates the flavor of kormas and meat curries. Garam masala is a blend of cardamom, cloves, cinnamon,

fennel, cumin, and coriander. Each state and region in India has its own signature garam masala. Any South Indian garam masala should work for all the curries in this book.

In addition to these essential spices, several herbs are also commonly used in South Indian dishes.

Dried bay leaves are used in biryanis and korma recipes. Some exotic and unique spices like kapok buds and black stone flower are also used, but they are not essential for this book's recipes.

Curry leaves are the leaves of the curry tree (*Murraya koenigii*) and are used as a natural aromatic in cooking. In languages spoken in South India, curry leaves are known as *karuveppilai* (Tamil), *karivepaku* (Telugu), *karibevu* (Kannada), and *karuveppila* (Malayalam). "Kari" can mean black and also curry (the spiced sauce.) Curry leaves are called sweet *neem* or black *neem*. The leaves resemble neem leaves, but they are darker in color, and they are not bitter—hence the name black neem or sweet neem.

Curry leaves are used in stews, gravies, curries, and salads. You can add curry leaves while tempering or while the sauce is simmering. There is no substitute for curry leaves. If you can't source them, you can skip them.

TEMPERING

Tempering is an Indian cooking technique whereby whole spices are fried in fat (oil or ghee) and heated to a high temperature to release their essential flavors and aromas. Tempering also refers to the results of this technique. The addition of tempering elevates the taste of dishes.

Tempering is added at the beginning of some recipes, like upma; in others, like chutneys, it is added at the end. For some curries and gravies, it doesn't matter when the tempering is added.

Most South Indian recipes call for mustard seeds in tempering, and they are cooked until they sputter, releasing sulfur, which acts as a natural preservative.

Along with mustard seeds, tempering may use Bengal gram, black lentils, cumin seeds, red chiles, curry leaves, and asafoetida.

For tempering with oil, an oil with a high smoke point is needed. You can use coconut oil, sesame oil, corn oil, vegetable oil, or canola oil. You can also use ghee (clarified butter). But because the smoke point of (unclarified) butter and olive oil are low, they are not recommended.

Shopping Guide

When I first came to the United States, I found it quite challenging to find certain spices. Now I can find all the Indian spices I need in the Asian aisle in most grocery stores. If you have an Indian grocery store in your area, you can find not only a full range of spices, but also some of the cookware and utensils used in Indian cooking.

You can find any number of brands in Indian grocery stores. When it comes to South Indian cuisine, I have some favorites, including 24 Mantra organic rice varieties, lentils, and beans. I also like the Deep, Udupi, and Shastha brands for rice, lentils, and legumes. I prefer Deep for tempering spices such as mustard seeds, cumin seeds, coriander seeds, fenugreek seeds, and fennel seeds. For recipes that call for flours, like rice flour or chickpea flour, I prefer Udupi. When it comes to spice powders, I prefer Sakthi or MTR.

If you love idli and dosa, ready-made batters are available in the refrigerator aisle of Indian grocery stores.

When shopping for tamarind, look for blocks that are shelled and seeded to save time. For tamarind paste, I prefer Joy or Laxmi brands.

Check out the frozen section for shredded coconut and also for rare vegetables like drumstick/moringa pods, tender jackfruit, and true yams.

Where to shop online:

You can purchase most Indian groceries, cookware, and utensils online. I have bought an Indian stovetop pressure cooker, wet grinders, and spices online. I've used Amazon and also have tried the online store KhanaPakana.com for spice mixes. If you live in the Bay Area, India Cash and Carry has an online presence, and its local stores will deliver right to your doorstep.

Savory Rice Crêpes

CHAPTER 3

Breakfast

South India—home of idli, upma, and various types of crêpes and rice noodles—is known for its breakfast, also referred to as *tiffin*, which means "light meal." Because most of these breakfast items—especially the idli and dosa varieties—are very light and easy to prepare, they are often included on dinner menus as well. It's hard to find a South Indian kitchen without idli and dosa batter, which you can also use to prepare a variety of crêpes. Breakfast dishes are typically served with assorted chutneys and sambar.

Idli | Savory Rice Cakes

Prep time: 20 minutes, plus 6 to 8 hours to soak and 8 to 10 hours to ferment | Cook time: 15 minutes

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Idli is one of the signature dishes of South India—and it makes for a very healthy breakfast. Idlis, which are steamed, contain no saturated fat or cholesterol, and the fermented batter aids digestion. This traditional Tamil Nadu–style recipe is prepared with idli rice. In other South Indian states, cream of rice is used. **SERVES 8**

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2 cups idli rice, rinsed at least four times in cold water, drained well

½ cup husked whole black lentils, rinsed at least four times in cold water, drained well

1 teaspoon fenugreek seeds

2¼ cups cold water, divided

4 ice cubes

1 teaspoon salt

4 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

1. In a large bowl, combine the rice and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. In a medium bowl, combine the lentils, fenugreek seeds, and enough cold water to cover by 3 to 4 inches. Let both soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours.
2. Drain the lentils and fenugreek seeds and transfer them to a blender. Blend until smooth, adding ½ to ¾ cup cold water, a little at a time. Transfer the lentils to a large bowl.
3. Drain the rice and add half to the blender. Add 2 ice cubes and about ½ cup of cold water and blend until smooth. Transfer the rice to the bowl with the ground lentils.

4. Add the remaining rice, 2 ice cubes, and ½ cup of cold water to the blender. Grind the rice until smooth and add it to the bowl. Rinse the blender with the remaining ½ cup of cold water and add it to the batter. Add the salt.
5. Using clean hands, mix the batter so the lentils and rice are well combined. The batter should be thick. Cover the bowl with a lid or plastic wrap and place it in a warm place—I keep mine in the oven with the light on—to ferment for 8 to 10 hours. The batter should double in size and look frothy. Using a spoon or ladle, mix the batter one more time before preparing the idlis.
6. Pour 1 cup of water into the steamer vessel and bring it to a boil over medium heat. Grease each mold on the idli plate with ¼ teaspoon of oil. Fill each mold three-quarters full with batter. Arrange the plates and place them inside the steamer. Cover the steamer, reduce the heat to medium-low, and steam the idlis for 10 minutes.
7. Turn off the heat and let the idlis cool, still covered in the steamer, for 5 minutes.
8. Using a spoon, remove the idlis from the molds. Serve hot.

COOKING TIP: Mixing the idli batter with your hands helps the fermentation.

Dosai | Savory Rice Crêpes

Prep time: 20 minutes, plus 6 to 8 hours to soak and 8 to 10 hours to ferment | Cook time: 10 minutes

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Dosai*, or dosa, are crispy, savory crêpes. In many Indian kitchens, the batter is prepared in bulk and, once fermented, refrigerated for up to a week.* **SERVES 8**

---

2 cups idli rice rinsed at least four times in cold water, drained well

½ cup husked whole black lentils, rinsed at least four times in cold water, drained well

1 teaspoon fenugreek seeds

2¼ cups cold water, divided

4 ice cubes

1 teaspoon salt

½ cup water, plus more as needed

8 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

1. In a large bowl, combine the rice and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. In a medium bowl, combine the lentils, fenugreek seeds, and enough cold water to cover by 3 to 4 inches. Let both soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours.
2. Drain the lentils and fenugreek seeds. Add them to a blender and blend until smooth, adding ½ to ¾ cup cold water, a little at a time. Transfer the lentils to a large bowl.
3. Drain the rice and add half to the blender. Add 2 ice cubes and ½ cup of cold water and blend until smooth. Transfer this to the bowl with the ground lentils.

4. Add the remaining rice, 2 ice cubes, and ½ cup of cold water to the blender and grind until smooth. Add it the rice to the bowl. Rinse the blender with the remaining ½ cup of cold water and add it to the batter. Add the salt.
5. Using clean hands, mix the batter until the lentils and rice are well combined, the batter should be thick. Cover the bowl with a lid or plastic wrap and place it in a warm place to ferment for 8 to 10 hours. The batter should double in size and look frothy. Using a spoon or ladle, mix the batter one more time before preparing the dosai.
6. Transfer 2 to 3 cups of batter to a medium bowl and stir in ½ cup of water, or more as needed, until the batter has a pouring consistency a little thicker than pancake batter.
7. Heat a round cast iron or nonstick griddle over medium heat.
8. Reduce the heat to low and pour a ladleful of batter onto the griddle. Using the back of the ladle, spread the batter around the griddle starting from the middle and moving out toward the edges. A super thin dosa is called *paper dosa,* and those a little thicker are called *kal dosa*.
9. Spread 1 teaspoon of oil around the edges of the dosa. Increase the heat to medium and cook the dosa for 45 to 50 seconds. Using a flat spatula, loosen the edges and carefully flip the dosa. Cook for 25 to 30 seconds before removing it from the griddle. Repeat with the remaining batter and oil. Serve hot.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of idli rice, you can use millet in the batter.

Upma | Savory Semolina Porridge

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 15 minutes

Upma is increasing in popularity worldwide. This thick savory porridge prepared with roasted semolina is known by different names, such as uppittu, Khara bath, *and* uppumavu. *My version is flavored with dill, coconut oil, and asafoetida.* **SERVES 4**

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1 tablespoon coconut oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon Bengal gram

2 green chiles, finely chopped

1 teaspoon asafoetida

1 curry leaf sprig

2 cups water

1¼ teaspoons salt

1 tablespoon plain Greek yogurt

1 cup roasted semolina, or upma mix

1 teaspoon finely chopped fresh dill

1 teaspoon ghee

Coconut Chutney, for serving

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the coconut oil.
2. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, and Bengal gram. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
3. Add the green chiles, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Cook for 45 seconds.

4. Add the water and salt. Bring the water to a rolling boil and stir in the yogurt.
5. Reduce the heat to medium-low and slowly add the semolina, stirring constantly to avoid lumps. Once all the semolina is added, stir vigorously to avoid lumps and achieve a consistent texture throughout. Partially cover the skillet and cook for 2 minutes.
6. Turn off the heat. Stir in the dill and ghee, mixing thoroughly. Partially re-cover the skillet and let sit for 5 minutes. Serve hot with coconut chutney.

COOKING TIP: Roasted semolina is readily available in Indian grocery stores. If you can't find it, get unroasted semolina (*sooji*) and dry-roast it in a skillet over medium heat for 4 to 5 minutes.

Neer Dosa | Soft and Lacy Rice Crêpes

Prep time: 20 minutes, plus 6 hours to soak | Cook time: 15 minutes

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Neer dosa *means water dosa, or crêpes. These gluten-free rice crêpes with their hint of coconut are popular in Mangalore and Udupi. Serve them with chutney, sambar, or a chicken curry, such as Kori Gassi and Mutton Curry*. **MAKES 5**

½ cup raw rice, sona masoori or ponni varieties, rinsed at least twice with cold water, drained well

2 tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 teaspoon salt

¾ cup water

5 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

1. In a large bowl, combine the rice and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours.
2. Drain the rice and place it in a blender. Add the coconut and salt and pulse to combine. With the blender running, slowly add the water (I use the entire amount) until a smooth, runny batter forms.
3. Heat a dosa griddle or well-seasoned cast iron griddle over medium heat. Pour a thin layer of batter with a circular motion starting from the edge of the griddle and pouring toward the middle. You don't need to spread the batter as you do when making regular dosa. Fill any gaps that may form with batter.

4. Drizzle 1 teaspoon of oil around the edges of the batter. Cover the dosa and cook for about 1 minute. Remove the lid, use a spatula to flip the dosa, and cook for just 5 to 7 seconds more. Fold the dosa in half and then fold it in half a second time, creating a triangle shape (you can do this either on the griddle or transfer it to a plate first). Repeat with the remaining batter and oil.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of raw rice, you can use idli rice or any millet variety. The soaking time remains the same. You might need another ¼ cup of water when grinding the rice, but that depends upon the quality of the rice, too.

Pesarattu | Green Mung Bean Crêpes

Prep time: 20 minutes, plus 6 to 8 hours to soak | Cook time: 20 minutes

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South India is known for its varieties of crêpes, or dosai. This green mung bean dosa is a traditional dish from Andhra/Telangana and is usually served with spicy ginger chutney. Topped with onions and flavored with green chiles and ginger, pesarattu is a wholesome protein-rich meal thanks to the mung beans. Fill this pesarattu with Upma, and enjoy a delicious and filling breakfast. **MAKES 10**

---

1 cup green mung beans, rinsed at least twice in cool water, drained well

1 tablespoon idli rice, rinsed at least twice in cool water, drained well

1 tablespoon husked whole black lentils, rinsed at least twice in cool water, drained well

2 teaspoons finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

2 green chiles, finely chopped

1½ teaspoons salt

1½ cups water

½ cup finely chopped onion

¼ cup finely chopped fresh cilantro

10 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

Ginger Chutney, for serving

1. In a large bowl, combine the green mung beans, rice, and black lentils and add enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours.
2. Drain the mung beans, rice, and lentils and transfer to a blender. Add the ginger, green chiles, and salt and pulse the

blender a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly pour in the water (I use the entire amount) until you have a smooth batter.

3. In a small bowl, stir together the onion and cilantro.
4. Heat a cast iron griddle or nonstick griddle over medium heat.
5. Reduce the heat to low and pour a ladleful of batter onto the griddle. Using the back of the ladle, spread the batter around the griddle, starting from the middle and moving out toward the edges.
6. Spread 1 teaspoon of oil around the edges of the pesarattu. Sprinkle some onion and cilantro on the top of the batter. Increase the heat to medium and cook the dosa for 60 to 80 seconds. The color on the top of the crêpe will change to a pale green. Using a spatula, loosen the edges of the crêpe and carefully flip it. Cook for 30 to 40 seconds more. Transfer the crêpe to a plate. If any of the onion falls off, place it back on top.
7. Repeat with the remaining batter, oil, and onion and cilantro topping. Serve hot with ginger chutney.

INGREDIENT TIP: The black lentils and idli rice give the dosa a nice texture. If you prefer, skip the black lentils and add 1 more tablespoon of rice. You can also use raw rice, or even quinoa.

Puttu | Steamed Rice Cakes Layered with Coconut

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Puttu, or pittu*, is a mild breakfast from Kerala that is also quite popular across South India and Sri Lanka.* Puttu *means "portioned" in the Malayalam language. The ground rice/wheat batter is steamed with layers of coconut. You need a special cylindrical puttu steamer (easily found online) to make these rice cakes. Serve them with any of the curries in this book or with sugar and banana.* **MAKES 6**

---

1 cup white puttu flour

¼ teaspoon salt

½ cup water

1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1. In a large bowl, combine the flour and salt. Slowly add the water to the bowl while using your fingers to mix the flour and water together until it is a cornmeal consistency. The amount of water you need depends on the quality and type of puttu flour you use.
2. Fill the bottom pot of the puttu steamer three-quarters full with water and close it. Bring the water to a boil so steam comes from the nozzle.
3. Place 2 tablespoons of shredded coconut in the steaming cylinder. Add enough batter to fill one-quarter of the cylinder. Add another 2 tablespoons of coconut, followed by an

additional one-quarter-cylinder amount of batter. Close the cylinder and place it on top of the steaming pot. Steam for 4 minutes.

4. Remove the cylinder from the pot. Carefully open the lid and remove the puttu. Repeat with the remaining batter and coconut.

COOKING TIP: You can also steam the puttu in a regular pot. Pour about 2 cups water into a pot and place a steel plate or rack in the water. Prepare the batter as directed but in a stainless steel or heatproof bowl. Stir in the coconut. Place the bowl on the plate or rack in the pot. Cover the pot and steam the puttu for 5 minutes.

Appam | Soft Rice Pancakes

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 6 to 8 hours to soak and 8 to 10 hours to ferment | Cook time: 20 minutes

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Appams are soft, lacy, bowl-shaped rice and coconut pancakes made with a fermented, slightly sweet batter. They are usually served with vegetable or meat stews, or with coconut milk and sugar. Yeast is usually used to ferment the appam batter, but a friend taught me the trick of using day-old cooked rice instead. The cooked rice gives the pancakes a soft, lacy texture. They get their shape from the appam pan or the small appachatti *(the Tamil word for appam pan) in which they are cooked.*
MAKES 10

---

1 cup raw rice, sona masoori or ponni variety, rinsed at least twice under cool water, drained well

1 cup cooked rice, preferably a day old, at room temperature

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 teaspoon sugar

1 teaspoon salt

1½ cups water, divided

1. In a large bowl, combine the raw rice and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours. Drain.
2. In a blender, combine the drained raw rice, cooked rice, coconut, sugar, and salt. Pulse the blender a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add 1 cup of water until it forms a smooth, runny batter. Transfer the batter to a large

bowl. Rinse the blender with the remaining ½ cup of water and pour this into the bowl with the batter. Stir well.

3. Cover the bowl with a lid or plastic wrap and place it in a warm place to ferment for 8 to 10 hours. Stir the batter before cooking it.
4. Heat the appam pan over medium heat.
5. Reduce the heat to low and add one ladleful of batter. Rotate the pan to spread the batter and form a bowl shape. Increase the heat to medium, cover the pan, and cook for 1½ to 2 minutes. Once cooked, the edges will separate from the pan. Using a spatula, remove the appam from the pan. Repeat with the remaining batter.

INGREDIENT TIP: If you don't have cooked rice, use ½ teaspoon instant dry yeast. After making the batter in the blender, add the yeast, mix well, cover, and ferment.

Adai | Mixed Lentil Pancakes

Prep time: 20 minutes, plus 6 hours to soak | Cook time: 20 minutes

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Adai *is a savory protein-rich rice and lentil pancake usually served with* Avial *or ghee and jaggery.* **MAKES 10**

---

2 dried Guntur chiles

½ cup raw rice, sona masoori or ponni variety, rinsed at least four times with cool water, drained well

2 tablespoons husked whole black lentils, rinsed at least four times with cool water, drained well

2 tablespoons Bengal gram, rinsed at least four times with cool water, drained well

2 tablespoons split yellow mung beans, rinsed at least four times with cool water, drained well

2 tablespoons split pigeon peas, rinsed at least four times with cool water, drained well

½ to ¾ cup water

1½ teaspoons salt

¼ cup finely chopped onion

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

10 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

Avial, for serving

1. In a large bowl, combine the Guntur chiles and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 6 to 8 hours. Drain.
2. In a blender, combine the rice, black lentils, Bengal gram, split lentils, pigeon peas, and the soaked chiles. Pulse the blender a few times to grind.

3. With the blender running, slowly pour in ½ cup of water and blend until the adai batter is thick and a bit coarse, but still pourable. Use up to ¼ cup more water, as needed. Transfer the batter to a large bowl. Stir in the salt, onion, and cilantro.
4. Heat a griddle over medium heat.
5. Reduce the heat to low and pour a ladleful of batter onto the griddle. Using the back of the ladle, spread the batter around the griddle starting from the middle. Drizzle 1 teaspoon of oil around the edges of the adai. Increase the heat to medium and cook for 60 to 90 seconds. Using a spatula, loosen the edges of the adai and carefully flip it. Cook for 30 to 40 seconds more. Transfer the adai to a plate. Repeat with the remaining batter and oil. Serve with avial, chutney, or powdered jaggery and ghee.

VARIATION TIP: For a kid-approved adai, after flipping, sprinkle your cheese of choice over the adai and let it melt. A cheesy, spicy adai is served!

Ragi Mudde | Savory Finger Millet Balls

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 8 minutes

Ragi mudde is a popular dish from Karnataka and the Rayalaseema region of Andhra. In Tamil Nadu, it is known as ragi kali. *Ragi (finger millet) mudde (cooked/steamed flour) are steamed finger millet balls. Like other South Indian steamed breakfast recipes, this recipe uses very little oil. The resulting dish is filling and healthy. I make ragi mudde with an indentation in each ball that I fill with gravy.* **SERVES 6**

2 cups water

¼ teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon vegetable or corn oil, plus more as needed

1 cup finger millet (ragi) flour

Soppu Saaru, for serving

1. In a medium pot over high heat, bring the water to a rolling boil. Add the salt and oil.
2. Slowly add the flour and, using the back of the wooden ladle, vigorously mix the flour to avoid lumps. Once the flour is mixed in, reduce the heat to medium, cover the pot, and cook for 2 minutes. Turn off the heat and let it sit for 10 to 15 minutes until the dough is hot, but can be handled safely.
3. Wet your palms with cold water. Divide the dough into six portions and, using your hands, form each into a ball the size of a small lemon. If the dough sticks to your hands, grease your palms with oil and continue to form the balls. If you are adding

these to a gravy or curry, I recommend pressing an indentation into each ball with your thumb.

4. Serve with soppu saaru.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: You can replace the finger millet flour with pearl millet or jowar flour.

Akki Roti | Rice Flour Flatbread

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Akki *means "rice" in Kannada and* roti *means "flatbread." This delicious, flavor-packed flatbread is from Karnataka. The dill, cilantro, onion, and carrot make this akki roti both a colorful and filling breakfast. Because this recipe calls for gluten-free flour, we need to flatten the roti using our hands rather than a rolling pin.* **MAKES 5**

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1 cup rice flour

½ cup finely chopped onion

2 tablespoons shredded carrot

1 tablespoon finely chopped fresh dill

1 tablespoon finely chopped fresh cilantro

¾ teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon red chile powder

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

½ cup water

Banana leaves, if using Method 1 to cook (optional)

5 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

1. In a large bowl, stir together the flour, onion, carrot, dill, cilantro, salt, chile powder, and asafoetida.
2. Add the water a little at a time while using your fingers to mix the flour into the water until a smooth firm dough forms. Divide the dough into five equal parts.
3. There are two methods to make the roti:

Method 1: Grease a banana leaf or a piece of parchment paper with 1 teaspoon of oil. Place a dough piece in the center and press it gently with the heel of your palm into a thin circle, $\frac{1}{4}$ to $\frac{1}{3}$ inch thick. If the dough is sticky, wet your palm with water. Make a small hole in the center of the dough.

Heat a griddle over medium heat. Carefully flip the roti onto your hand, leaving the banana leaf on top of the dough, and place the roti on the griddle. Cook for 10 seconds. Gently and carefully lift the banana leaf from the top of the dough. Continue cooking the akki roti for 1 minute more. Using a spatula, flip it. Spread 1 teaspoon of oil around the edges of the roti and in the middle hole and cook for 1 minute more. Transfer the roti to a plate. Repeat with the remaining dough and oil.

Method 2: This is the traditional method and the one I use. Spread 1 teaspoon of oil on a cold griddle. Place a piece of dough in the center of the griddle and use the heel of your palm to press it gently into a thin circle. If the dough is sticky, wet your palm with water. Make a small hole in the center of the dough.

Place the griddle with the roti over medium heat. Cook for about 4 minutes. Using a spatula, flip the roti and cook for 1 more minute. Using a spatula, transfer the roti to a plate.

Turn off the heat and let the griddle cool for 10 minutes. Press the next roti and cook as directed.

VARIATION TIP: You can add other veggies to your akki roti, like shredded cabbage and bell pepper. When you add more vegetables, the cooking time increases, usually by about 2 minutes.

Tamarind Rice

CHAPTER 4

Rice and Grains

Rice, especially steamed rice, is the traditional accompaniment to curries. South India has a variety of flavored rice dishes, many of which are part of everyday cooking. Some dishes, such as sweet jaggery rice, are made only during festivals.

Nutrient-rich millet and sorghum are also widely used. Ragi porridge, ragi balls, and sorghum roti are quite popular. Millet, once considered only bird food, is slowly coming back into use as an excellent substitute for rice. Varieties of millet include barnyard millet, kodo millet, proso millet, little millet, and foxtail millet; any variety can be used instead of rice.

Bisi Bele Bath | Rice and Lentils Dish

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Bisi bele bath, *"hot lentil and rice dish" in the Kannada language, is a popular Karnataka dish that's wholesome, filling, and loaded with vegetables. It can be prepared with store-bought bisi bele bath masala powder, but this recipe includes instructions for making your own fresh powder. You can prepare the powder ahead of time, and it can be stored in an airtight container for up to 2 days. Serve this dish hot with any dry curry, such as Potato-Onion Curry, Bitter Gourd Jaggery Stir-Fry, Lentil and Vegetable Salad, or Cabbage Palya.* **SERVES 6**

FOR THE BISI BELE BATH POWDER

4 dried red chiles, preferably byadgi chiles

3 green cardamom pods

3 whole cloves

2 curry leaf sprigs

1½ tablespoons coriander seeds

1½ tablespoons Bengal gram

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

½ teaspoon husked whole black lentils

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon peppercorns

½ teaspoon fenugreek seeds

2 kapok buds (optional)

FOR THE MASALA

2 tablespoons ghee

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon fenugreek seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 curry leaf sprig

½ cup finely chopped onion

2 Roma tomatoes, finely chopped

2½ teaspoons salt

2 teaspoons powdered jaggery

2 teaspoons tamarind paste

3 cups chopped mixed vegetables, such as bell pepper, eggplant, beans, zucchini, carrot

¾ cup sona masoori rice, rinsed, soaked in water for 20 minutes, drained

¾ cup split pigeon peas, rinsed, drained, soaked in water for 20 minutes, drained

4 cups water

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

TO MAKE THE BISI BELE BATH POWDER

1. Heat a large skillet over medium heat.
2. Add the chiles, cardamom, cloves, curry leaves, coriander seeds, Bengal gram, cinnamon, black lentils, cumin seeds, peppercorns, fenugreek seeds, and kapok buds (if using). Dry-roast the spices for 3 to 4 minutes until the Bengal gram turns light brown. Turn off the heat and let the spices cool.
3. Transfer the spices to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.

TO MAKE THE MASALA

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, select Sauté and add the ghee to melt. If using a stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, heat the pan over medium heat and add the ghee to melt.
2. Once melted, add the mustard seeds, fenugreek seeds, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.

3. Add the onion and cook for 3 to 4 minutes, or until the onion is soft and translucent.
4. Stir in the tomatoes, salt, jaggery, and tamarind paste and cook for 3 minutes, or until the tomatoes become soft and are broken down.
5. Add the vegetables and stir in the bisi bele bath powder until thoroughly mixed.
6. Add the rice, pigeon peas, and water. Mix well.
7. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 20 minutes on High Pressure. Once the cooking is complete, let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and put the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 4 or 5 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
8. Carefully unlock and remove the lid. Stir in the cilantro.

COOKING TIP: I like this dish nut free, but you can roast 10 to 15 whole cashew nuts or peanuts in ghee with the spices before cooking the onion.

Pulihora | Tamarind Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Every South Indian state has its own version of tamarind rice. In Karnataka, it is called puliogare*; in Tamil Nadu, it is known as* puliodarai*; and in Andhra/Telangana, it is known as* pulihora*. A popular dish for festivals, tamarind rice is served in temple kitchens as an offering. This Andhra/Telangana–style pulihora is tangy and spicy with a hint of ginger. I love to pack this rice for my lunch. Serve it hot with any vegetable curry or papad, such as Potato-Onion Curry, Cabbage Palya, or Lentil and Vegetable Salad.* **SERVES 4**

1 cup sona masoori rice, rinsed with cool water, drained, and cooked according to the package directions

3 tablespoons sesame oil, divided

1 small lime-size seedless tamarind block, soaked in ½ cup boiling water for 30 minutes

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

2 teaspoons husked whole black lentils

2 teaspoons Bengal gram

2 curry leaf sprigs

3 dried Guntur chiles, halved lengthwise

3 tablespoons peanuts

½ teaspoon asafoetida

2 green chiles, finely chopped

1 tablespoon finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

1½ teaspoons salt

½ teaspoon ground mustard

⅛ teaspoon ground turmeric

1. Spread the cooked rice on a plate and drizzle 1 tablespoon of sesame oil over it. Set aside.
2. Stir the tamarind and the water it has been soaking in. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside.
3. In a large pan or wok over medium heat, heat the remaining 2 tablespoons of sesame oil.
4. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, curry leaves, and Guntur chiles. Cook until the oil becomes frothy.
5. Add the peanuts and asafoetida. Cook for 1 minute until the peanuts turn light brown.
6. Add the green chiles and ginger and cook for 1 minute.
7. Reduce the heat to medium-low and add the tamarind pulp, salt, mustard, and turmeric. Simmer for 10 minutes. The mixture will thicken as it simmers.
8. Reduce the heat to low and cook for 3 minutes more. The mixture should be thick, like the consistency of jam. Turn off the heat. Add the mixture to the rice and stir thoroughly to combine.

MAKE IT NUT-FREE: Peanuts are a traditional ingredient in tamarind rice, but they can be omitted. Instead, add 3 tablespoons cooked black or white chickpeas.

Lemon Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Lemon and turmeric make this dish vibrant and refreshing. The coconut oil, tempering spices, and cilantro add complex flavors. Serve this rice with potatoes or any vegetable curry, such as Cabbage Palya, for a complete meal. **SERVES 4**

1 cup short-grain rice, such as sona masoori, rinsed with cool water, drained, and cooked according to the package instructions

1 tablespoon coconut oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon Bengal gram

2 green chiles, finely chopped

1 curry leaf sprig

3 tablespoons peanuts

1 teaspoon ground turmeric

1½ teaspoons salt

Juice of 1 medium lemon

¼ cup finely chopped fresh cilantro

1. Spread the cooked rice on a plate, fluff it with a fork, and set aside.
2. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the coconut oil.
3. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, green chiles, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.

4. Add the peanuts and cook for 1 minute. Turn off the heat and stir in the turmeric.
5. Add the mustard seed mixture, salt, and lemon juice to the cooked rice and stir until thoroughly mixed.
6. Gently fold in the cilantro.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Leftover rice works well for this recipe. Use about 3 cups of cooked rice.

Coconut Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

This fragrant, easy-to-prepare coconut rice is served at most South Indian festivals. Serve it hot with any vegetable curry or papad, such as Potato-Onion Curry or Cabbage Palya. **SERVES 4**

1 cup sona masoori rice, rinsed with cold water, drained, and cooked according to the package instructions

2 tablespoons coconut oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

1 teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon Bengal gram

2 curry leaf sprigs

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 dried Guntur chile, halved

2 green chiles, finely chopped

5 whole cashews

1 tablespoon peanuts

1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1½ teaspoons salt

1 tablespoon chopped fresh cilantro

1. Spread the cooked rice on a plate, fluff it with a fork, and set aside.
2. In a large pan or wok over medium heat, heat the coconut oil.

3. Add the mustard seeds, cumin seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, curry leaves, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the Guntur chile, green chiles, cashews, and peanuts. Cook for about 1 minute until the nuts turn light brown.
5. Reduce the heat to low and add the coconut and salt. Roast the coconut with the spices for about 5 minutes. Turn off the heat. Add the coconut mixture to the rice and stir until mixed thoroughly.
6. Stir in the cilantro.

COOKING TIP: Fresh coconut is delicious in this dish but frozen coconut will be fine if that's what you have.

Vangi Bath | Brinjal Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Like Bisi Bele Bath, this rice can be made quickly with store-bought masala, but it is best with freshly ground spices. This is my recipe using graffiti-variety eggplant. Vangi bath spice powder is versatile: You can use it for all your curries. **SERVES 4**

1 cup sona masoori rice, rinsed with cool water, drained, and cooked according to the package directions

FOR THE VANGI BATH POWDER

4 red chiles, preferably byadgi chiles

2 whole cloves

2 green cardamom pods

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

1 teaspoon coriander seeds

1 teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon Bengal gram

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon poppy seeds

¼ teaspoon fenugreek seeds

¼ teaspoon peppercorns

2 teaspoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

FOR THE SPICED EGGPLANT

2 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon Bengal gram

2 curry leaf sprigs

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

½ cup finely chopped onion

2 graffiti eggplants (brinjals), cut into 2-inch pieces (about 2 cups)

2 teaspoons salt

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 tablespoon water

½ teaspoon powdered jaggery

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

1 small marble-size seedless tamarind block, soaked in ½ cup boiling water for 30 minutes

Spread the cooked rice on a plate and fluff it with a fork. Set aside.

TO MAKE THE VANGI BATH POWDER

1. Place a large skillet over medium heat.
2. Add the chiles, cloves, cardamom, cinnamon, coriander seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, cumin seeds, poppy seeds, fenugreek seeds, peppercorns, and coconut. Dry-roast for 3 to 4 minutes until the Bengal gram turns light brown. Turn off the heat and let the spices cool.
3. Transfer the spice mixture to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.

TO MAKE THE SPICED EGGPLANT

1. Stir the tamarind and the water it has been soaking in. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a

spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside.

2. Wipe out the skillet and place it, or a kadai, over medium heat and heat the vegetable oil.
3. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, and Bengal gram. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the curry leaves and asafoetida and cook for 30 seconds.
5. Add the onion and cook for 5 minutes, or until the onion is soft and translucent.
6. Add the eggplant, salt, turmeric, and water. Stir to combine, cover the skillet, and cook for 1 minute.
7. Stir in the jaggery, vangi bath powder, and tamarind pulp. Cook for 5 to 7 minutes until the water is absorbed. Turn off the heat.
8. Add the spiced eggplant mixture to the rice and stir until mixed thoroughly.
9. Stir in the cilantro.

INGREDIENT TIP: I prefer using a variety of brinjals for this recipe, but you can use regular purple baby eggplant. A seedless variety or a variety with fewer seeds would work great. Instead of brinjal, you can try other veggies, such as zucchini or ridge gourd.

Chettinadu Vegetable Biryani

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Chettinadu cuisine is a sub-cuisine of Tamil Nadu, known for its snacks and spicy curries. Biryani is one of the most popular dishes in India; every region has its signature version. This Chettinadu vegetable biryani is made with a fragrant Tamil Nadu rice called seeraga samba. Kapok buds and black stone flower make this recipe unique. Serve this biryani hot with any chicken curry, such as Country Chicken Curry from Andhra or Mutton Curry. Vegetarians can enjoy it with Vegetable Sagu. **SERVES 6**

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3 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil

1 dried bay leaf

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

2 green cardamom pods

3 whole cloves

1 kapok bud

1 small piece black stone flower

1 star anise

1 cup finely chopped onion

1 tablespoon ginger-garlic paste

2 green chiles, slit lengthwise

1 Roma tomato, finely chopped

20 fresh mint leaves

¼ cup finely chopped fresh cilantro

2 cups mixed vegetables, such as cauliflower, peas, potatoes, beans, and carrots

1 tablespoon salt

½ teaspoon red chile powder

1½ teaspoons ground coriander

⅛ teaspoon ground turmeric

2 cups water

1½ cups seeraga samba rice, rinsed in cool water, drained, soaked in water for 30 minutes, drained

1. In a large skillet or kadai over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil.
2. Reduce the heat to low and add the bay leaf, cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, kapok bud, black stone flower, and star anise. Cook for 30 seconds.
3. Add the onion, ginger-garlic paste, and green chiles. Sauté for 5 minutes, or until the onion is translucent.
4. Add the tomato, mint, and cilantro and cook for 3 minutes.
5. Add the mixed vegetables, salt, chile powder, coriander, and turmeric. Cover the skillet and cook for 2 minutes. Increase the heat to medium-high, and add the water. Bring the mixture to a rolling boil.
6. Add the rice, reduce the heat to medium, and cook for 5 minutes.
7. Reduce the heat to low, cover the skillet, and cook for 10 to 12 minutes, until the rice is steamed and the water is absorbed. Turn off the heat.
8. Let sit, covered, for 5 minutes. Use a fork to fluff the rice. Mix gently to combine.

INGREDIENT TIP: Instead of seeraga samba rice, you can use long-grain basmati rice. The cooking time and the rice-to-water ratio are the same. Black stone flower powder is readily available in Indian groceries if you can't find the flower pieces. If using the powder, use ¼ teaspoon for this recipe.

Nei Choru | Ghee Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 20 minutes soaking time | Cook time: 40 minutes

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Nei *is "ghee" and* choru *is "rice" in Malayalam. Nei choru is a popular delicacy from Kerala. It is prepared with a fragrant rice variety called kaima, or* jeerakasala. *The onions, raisins, and cashews fried in ghee add a unique flavor to the dish. Whether for a party or potluck, this rice is a crowd pleaser. Serve it hot with Egg Kurma or Potato-Onion Curry.*
SERVES 6

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3 tablespoons ghee
2 tablespoons cashews
2 tablespoons raisins
1 onion, thinly sliced, divided
4 whole cloves
4 green cardamom pods
1 (3-inch) cinnamon stick
1 green chile, halved lengthwise
2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
1½ cups water
1 teaspoon salt
1 cup kaima rice, rinsed in cool water, drained, soaked in water for 20 minutes, drained

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, melt the ghee.
2. Add the cashews and raisins. Cook for 30 to 45 seconds, until the raisins become plump. Transfer the nuts and raisins to a dish and set aside.

3. Increase the heat to medium-high. Add half the onion and cook for 12 to 15 minutes until browned. Transfer the onion to another bowl and set aside.
4. Reduce the heat to medium and add the cloves, cardamom, and cinnamon. Cook for 30 seconds.
5. Add the green chile, garlic, and the remaining onion. Cook for 5 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onion is soft and translucent.
6. Increase the heat to medium-high, add the water and salt, and bring to a rolling boil. Add the rice, reduce the heat to medium, and cook for 5 minutes.
7. Reduce the heat to low, cover the skillet, and cook for 10 to 12 minutes until the rice is steamed and the water is absorbed. Turn off the heat.
8. Let sit, covered, for 5 minutes. Use a fork to fluff the rice. Add the fried onions, cashews, and raisins to the rice and mix well.

INGREDIENT TIP: You can use long-grain basmati rice instead of kaima rice. The cooking time and the rice-to-water ratio are the same.

Mavinakayi Chitranna | Raw Mango Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

This rice dish comes from Karnataka. Chitranna *means "tangy lemon rice" in Kannada. In this recipe, the tang comes from raw mango, or* mavinakayi. *Raw mango cubes add texture to this dish flavored with sesame seeds and coconut.* **SERVES 4**

1 cup sona masoori rice, rinsed in cool water, drained, and cooked according to the package instructions

1 tablespoon plus ½ teaspoon vegetable or corn oil, divided

1½ teaspoons fenugreek seeds

1½ teaspoons white sesame seeds

4 dried Guntur chiles

½ teaspoon asafoetida

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon husked whole black lentils

½ teaspoon Bengal gram

10 peanuts

½ cup shredded raw mango

½ cup raw mango cubes

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

2 teaspoons salt

1 teaspoon powdered jaggery

1. Spread the cooked rice on a plate and fluff it with a fork. Set aside.
2. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat ½ teaspoon of the oil.

3. Add the fenugreek seeds, sesame seeds, Guntur chiles, and asafoetida. Dry-roast the spices for 1 minute. Turn off the heat, and stir in the coconut. Let cool.
4. Transfer the spice mixture to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a coarse powder. Set aside.
5. Return the skillet to medium heat and heat the remaining 1 tablespoon of oil.
6. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, and peanuts. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
7. Add the shredded and the cubed mango and turmeric. Cook for 7 minutes, stirring frequently, until the mango no longer smells raw. Stir in the salt and jaggery and cook for 2 minutes more. Turn off the heat.
8. Add the rice to the chitranna mixture in the skillet and gently stir to combine.

COOKING TIP: I like the crunch of the mango cubes, but you can use all shredded mango if you prefer.

Ven Pongal | Savory Rice with Split Yellow Mung Beans

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

This popular savory breakfast made with rice and yellow split lentils is often paired with vadai *(lentil fritters) and served with sambar and chutney. It's a satisfying breakfast when served with Coconut Chutney and Mixed Vegetable Sambar.* **SERVES 8**

1½ cups short-grain rice, such as sona masoori, rinsed in cool water, drained

½ cup split yellow mung beans, rinsed and drained

1½ tablespoons peppercorns, divided

2 curry leaf sprigs

1½ teaspoons salt

5 cups water

3 tablespoons ghee, or clarified butter

2 tablespoons cumin seeds

10 whole cashews

1 tablespoon finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the rice, split yellow mung beans, 1 tablespoon of peppercorns, curry leaves, salt, and water. Mix thoroughly.
2. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure

Cook or Manual and set the time for 8 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 4 or 5 times. Let the pressure release naturally.

3. Carefully unlock and remove the lid. Using a spatula, mix and mash the pongal.
4. Heat a small skillet over medium heat, melt the ghee.
5. Add the cumin seeds, cashews, ginger, and the remaining ½ tablespoon of peppercorns. Cook for about 1 minute, stirring frequently, until the cashews turn light golden brown. Turn off the heat. Add the spice mixture to the mashed pongal, stirring until mixed thoroughly.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of short-grain white rice, use quinoa or millet. Increase the water by 1 cup; the cooking time is the same.

Sakkarai Pongal | Sweet Jaggery Rice

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 45 minutes

This sweet rice, prepared during the Pongal, or Sankranti Festival, is traditionally made with freshly harvested rice or new rice, split yellow mung beans (moong dal), jaggery, and milk. Like tamarind rice, it is served in temples, and it is made with edible camphor, which adds a unique flavor. **SERVES 4**

¼ cup split yellow mung beans

½ cup short-grain rice, such as sona masoori, rinsed in cool water, drained

2 cups plus 2 tablespoons water, divided

2 tablespoons ghee

10 raisins

10 cashews

¾ cup grated jaggery

1 whole clove, crushed using a heavy-bottomed pot or other heavy object

1 green cardamom pod, crushed using a heavy-bottomed pot or other heavy object

1 cup milk

⅛ teaspoon edible camphor (optional)

1. Heat a medium skillet or kadai over medium heat.
2. Add the split yellow mung beans and dry-roast for 5 to 7 minutes until they turn golden brown.
3. In a saucepan over medium heat, combine the rice, roasted mung beans, and 2 cups of water. Cook for 20 minutes, stirring every 3 minutes. Using a potato masher, mash the cooked rice and lentils in the pot.

4. In a large skillet or wok over medium heat, melt the ghee.
5. Add the raisins and cashews and cook for 30 to 45 seconds, until the raisins become plump. Transfer the raisins and cashews to a small dish and set aside.
6. Return the skillet to medium heat and add the remaining 2 tablespoons of water. When the water begins to simmer, add the jaggery and let it melt.
7. Stir in the clove, cardamom, milk, and the mashed rice and lentils.
8. Add the edible camphor (if using). Reduce the heat to low and cook for 10 to 12 minutes, stirring every 2 minutes. Turn off the heat.
9. Stir in the raisins and cashews.

INGREDIENT TIP: If the jaggery dissolves with no residue, there is no need to strain it. If there is residue, strain it through a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl, return the water to the pot, and continue with the recipe.

Cut Mango Pickles

CHAPTER 5

Chutneys and Pickles

Tangy and spicy chutneys and pickles often accompany tiffin and rice dishes. Generally, chutneys are served with breakfast and snacks, and pickles are served with rice. But some breakfast dishes, such as Upma, pair well with pickles, and various rice recipes pair wonderfully with chutneys.

Most chutneys are prepared by grinding sautéed vegetables and lentils with tamarind and chiles. They have a long shelf life when refrigerated in an airtight container. The summer months are the best time for making pickles with lemon, mango, ginger, garlic, and gooseberry. Prepared in bulk with fresh ingredients, they will keep for months.

Coconut Chutney

Prep time: 5 minutes | Cook time: 10 minutes

Be it Idli or Dosai, Upma or Ven Pongal, the South Indian breakfast is incomplete without this white chutney. You can even pair it with vadai and other snacks. It's a very simple chutney, prepared with coconut and roasted chickpeas, and spiced with green chiles. It can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 3 days. Use a clean spoon for each serving.

SERVES 6

1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

½ cup roasted split chickpeas

2 green chiles, finely chopped

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely chopped

1 teaspoon salt

1 cup water, divided

2 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

1 curry leaf sprig

1. In a blender, combine the coconut, roasted split chickpeas, green chiles, ginger, and salt. Pulse until the chickpeas are coarsely ground and a coarse consistency forms.
2. Add ½ cup of water and blend until a smooth paste forms. Transfer the chutney to a small bowl. Rinse the blender with the remaining ½ cup of water and add that to the chutney. Mix well.

3. Heat a small skillet over medium heat, add the oil and heat for 30 seconds.
4. Add the mustard seeds, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Stir the spice mix into the chutney until well mixed.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of roasted chickpeas, you can use almonds. Soak 10 almonds in hot water for 30 minutes. Remove their skins and coarsely grind them together with the coconut.

Onion-Tomato Chutney

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 15 minutes

Red chutney, a.k.a. onion-tomato chutney, is a tangy, spicy condiment. My version includes lentils for thickening and texture. This chutney is wonderful with Dosai, but you can serve it with any breakfast recipe or with rice. It can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 5 days. Use a clean spoon for each serving. **SERVES 6**

2 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

1 medium onion, roughly chopped

2 garlic cloves, peeled

3 dried Guntur chiles

1 tablespoon Bengal gram

1 tablespoon husked whole black lentils

3 tomatoes, roughly chopped

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

1 teaspoon salt

¼ cup water

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 curry leaf sprig

1. In a medium skillet over medium heat, heat 1 teaspoon of oil.
2. Add the onion and garlic and sauté for 5 to 7 minutes, until the onion browns slightly. Transfer the onion and garlic to a plate and set aside.

3. Return the skillet to medium heat and add the Guntur chiles, Bengal gram, and black lentils. Sauté for 1 minute, until the lentils turn slightly brown. Transfer these to a plate and set aside.
4. Return the skillet to medium heat and add the tomatoes. Sauté for 3 to 4 minutes until they soften. Turn off the heat and let the tomatoes cool.
5. In a blender, pulse the chiles, Bengal gram, and black lentils into a coarse powder.
6. Add the onion and garlic mixture, tomatoes, tamarind paste, and salt to the blender. With the blender running, slowly add up to $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of water and blend until a smooth paste forms. Transfer the paste to a bowl.
7. Heat a small skillet over medium heat. Add the remaining 1 teaspoon of oil and heat for 30 seconds.
8. Add the mustard seeds, asafoetida, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Stir the spice mixture into the chutney until well mixed.

INGREDIENT TIP: If the tomatoes are sour, skip the tamarind paste. For a fiery red color, use byadgi chiles in place of Guntur.

Allam Pachadi | Ginger Chutney

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 10 minutes

This sweet and spicy ginger chutney combines ginger and jaggery. Allam *means "ginger" in Telugu, and* pachadi *usually refers to pickles and chutneys. This ginger chutney is a popular dish of Andhra and Telangana and is usually served as a dip or sauce for snacks and breakfast dishes, especially Pesarattu. The chutney can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 5 days. Use a clean spoon for each serving.* **SERVES 6**

---

2 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

⅔ cup roughly chopped peeled fresh ginger

½ cup powdered jaggery

2 tablespoons tamarind paste

2½ teaspoons salt

1 tablespoon sugar (optional)

2 teaspoons red chile powder

½ teaspoon fenugreek powder

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

2 tablespoons water

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1 curry leaf sprig

1. In a small skillet over medium heat, heat 1½ tablespoons of oil.
2. Add the ginger and sauté for 3 to 4 minutes, being careful not to let it brown. Transfer the ginger to a dish and let cool.

3. In a blender, combine the cooled ginger, jaggery, tamarind paste, salt, sugar (if using), chile powder, fenugreek, and turmeric. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running add up to 2 tablespoons of water until a smooth paste forms.
4. Heat a small skillet over medium heat. Add the remaining oil and heat for 30 seconds.
5. Add the mustard seeds and garlic and cook for 60 to 90 seconds until the garlic browns and the mustard seeds begin to sputter.
6. Turn off the heat and add the curry leaves. Let the spices sit in the hot oil for 30 seconds. Stir the spice mixture into the chutney until mixed well.

INGREDIENT TIP: Although optional, sugar helps the chutney retain its color. If you can't find fenugreek powder, add ½ teaspoon fenugreek seeds while sautéing the ginger.

Cut Mango Pickles

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 10 minutes

Mangos are known as the king of fruits in India, and you can find seemingly countless varieties during the summer season. This recipe can be made with any available green mango. The pickles can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 1 week. Use a clean spoon for each serving. After a day or two, the salt in the pickles results in excess water; that's completely normal and expected. Stir the water into the pickles before serving. **SERVES 10**

1 green mango, cut into 1-inch cubes (about 3 cups)

3½ teaspoons salt

3 teaspoons red chile powder

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

2 tablespoons corn oil (a neutral oil works better here; vegetable oil infuses its own flavor)

1 tablespoon sesame oil

3 teaspoons mustard seeds

1½ teaspoons fenugreek seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1. In a medium bowl, stir together the mango, salt, chile powder, and turmeric until the mango is evenly coated with the spices.
2. Heat a small skillet over medium heat.
3. Add the corn oil and sesame oil and heat for 30 seconds.
4. Add the mustard seeds, fenugreek seeds, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute, and

turn off the heat. Stir this spice mixture into the mango until mixed well.

COOKING TIP: Adjust the amount of salt and red chile powder according to the sourness of the mango.

Lemon Pickles

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Lemon and mango pickles are the most common pickles found in Indian grocery stores. Traditionally, lemon pickles take some time to prepare because of their long soaking time. But my mother taught me a method for making instant lemon pickles (thanks, Mom!). These versatile pickles are best served with rice dishes and breakfast dishes like Upma.
SERVES 20

---

5 cups water
4 medium lemons, washed
5 teaspoons red chile powder
3 teaspoons salt
1 teaspoon ground mustard
½ teaspoon fenugreek powder
6 tablespoons sesame oil
2 teaspoons mustard seeds

1. In a large pot over high heat, bring the water to a rolling boil. Turn off the heat and add the whole lemons to the hot water. Let soak for 20 minutes. This helps the lemon soften. Remove the lemons from the water and cut into small wedges.
2. In a large bowl, combine the lemon wedges, chile powder, salt, ground mustard, and fenugreek powder. Toss until the lemon wedges are well coated with the spices.
3. Place a small skillet over medium heat. Add the sesame oil and heat for 30 seconds.

4. Add the mustard seeds and cook until they begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Stir the seeds into the lemon pickle until mixed well.
5. Refrigerate the pickles in an airtight container for up to several months.

VARIATION TIP: Instead of lemons you can use limes, but soak them in the hot water for no more than 10 minutes.

Curry Leaf, Mint, and Cilantro Chutney

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

This chutney with mint and cilantro is perfect for Idli and Dosai as well as rice dishes such as Lemon Rice. It can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 5 days. Use a clean spoon for each serving. **SERVES 8**

½ cup curry leaves

20 fresh mint leaves

2 tablespoons roughly chopped fresh cilantro

2 tablespoons husked whole black lentils

2 tablespoons Bengal gram

3 dried Guntur chiles

1 marble-size seedless tamarind block

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1¼ teaspoons salt

¾ cup water, divided

1 teaspoon vegetable or corn oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1. Heat a large skillet over medium heat.
2. Add the curry leaves, mint leaves, and cilantro. Dry-roast 4 to 5 minutes, until the curry leaves are crisp. Transfer to a plate and set aside.
3. Return the skillet to medium heat and add the black lentils, Bengal gram, and Guntur chiles. Dry-roast for 3 to 4 minutes

until the lentils turn light brown. Turn off the heat and add the tamarind to the hot pan so it softens a bit. Set aside to cool for about 10 minutes.

4. Transfer the lentil mixture to a blender and pulse into a coarse powder.
5. Add the curry leaves mixture, coconut, salt, and ½ cup of water and blend until a smooth paste forms. Transfer the paste to a medium bowl.
6. Rinse the blender with the remaining ¼ cup of water and add this to the bowl. Stir well to combine.
7. Heat a small skillet over medium heat. Add the oil and heat for 30 seconds.
8. Add the mustard seeds and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute, and turn off the heat. Stir this spice mixture into the chutney until mixed well.

INGREDIENT TIP: Vary the proportions of the curry leaves, cilantro, and mint according to your preference. If you use more mint, sauté it until it no longer smells raw.

Andhra Palli Chutney | Peanut Tamarind Chutney

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

This tangy and garlicky chutney is popular in the states of Andhra and Telangana and is perfect with Idli or any savory crêpe, such as Dosai, Neer Dosa, and Pesarattu. It also makes a tasty dip or sauce for chips and sandwiches. Roasted palli *("peanuts" in Telugu) make this chutney creamy. Keep it refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 5 days. Use a clean spoon for each serving.* **SERVES 10**

---

1 cup raw peanuts, skins removed

2 green chiles, halved lengthwise

1 dried Guntur chile

2 garlic cloves

1 teaspoon tamarind paste, or 1 small marble-size seedless tamarind block

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 teaspoon salt

1 cup water, divided

2 teaspoons vegetable or corn oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon husked whole black lentils

½ teaspoon Bengal gram

1 curry leaf sprig

1. Heat a large skillet over medium heat.
2. Add the peanuts and dry-roast for about 4 minutes until they turn light brown. Transfer them to a medium bowl and set

aside.

3. Return the skillet to the heat and add the green chiles, Guntur chile, and garlic. Dry-roast for 2 to 3 minutes until the garlic starts to brown. Turn off the heat and add the tamarind paste to soften a bit. Set aside to cool for about 10 minutes, or until the peanuts are completely cool.
4. In a blender, combine the cooled peanuts, green chiles, Guntur chile, garlic, tamarind, coconut, and salt. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add ¾ cup of water until a smooth paste forms. Transfer the paste to a medium bowl. Rinse the blender with the remaining ¼ cup of water and add this to the chutney. Stir well to combine.
5. Heat a small skillet over medium heat. Add the oil and cook for 30 seconds.
6. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, Bengal gram, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute, and turn off the heat. Stir the spice mixture into the chutney until mixed well.

INGREDIENT TIP: Leave out the coconut, if you wish, but it does add nice flavor to the chutney.

Gongura Pachadi | Sorrel Leaves Chutney

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

One of the signature recipes of Telugu cuisine is a chutney made with gongura, or sorrel leaves. When cooked, the leaves become sticky and tangy. They're usually spiced with red chiles and garlic. Serve this chutney with steamed rice and ghee to make it a meal. **SERVES 20**

3 tablespoons sesame oil, divided

1 teaspoon fenugreek seeds

5 dried Guntur chiles

3 cups sorrel leaves, or gongura, rinsed and finely chopped

3 garlic cloves, finely chopped

3 shallots, finely chopped

2 teaspoons salt

2 tablespoons water

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat 1 tablespoon of sesame oil.
2. Add the fenugreek seeds and Guntur chiles. Sauté for 45 seconds to 1 minute until fragrant. Transfer to a dish and set aside.
3. Return the skillet to medium heat and heat the remaining 2 tablespoons of oil.
4. Add the sorrel leaves, garlic, and shallots. Sauté for 7 to 8 minutes until the sorrel leaves wilt and no longer smell raw. Turn off the heat and let cool.

5. In a blender, combine the roasted fenugreek seeds and chiles, sorrel, garlic, shallots, salt, and water. Pulse into a coarse chutney. Refrigerate in an airtight container for about 5 days.

COOKING TIP: You can add more water when pulsing, but the shelf life of the chutney will be shorter. After pulsing, add one more tablespoon of sesame oil for more flavor.

Raw Banana (Plantain) Chips

CHAPTER 6

Snacks

Like breakfast, snacks are also called tiffins, and they are usually served with tea or coffee. A wide variety of snacks, like Soft Lentil Fritters, are enjoyed at festivals, but because most festival foods follow the sattvic diet, the snacks made during the festival season don't contain onion or garlic. Here I share popular street foods and traditional festival snack recipes.

Raw Banana (Plantain) Chips

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Kerala is known for its sweet and savory plantain chips. The sweet ones are yellow and made from the nendran *banana variety; the savory ones are made with raw (unripe) banana or plantains. Both versions are fried in coconut oil and lightly seasoned with salt and pepper. It's hard to say no to these chips, which are particularly irresistible when served with coffee or tea.* **SERVES 6**

1 plantain or unripe (raw) banana, peeled, ends trimmed, and very thinly sliced into rounds (about 60 rounds if using a mandoline)

1½ cups coconut oil

1 teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
2. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the coconut oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by dropping a small piece of sliced plantain into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.
3. Working in batches, one by one, carefully drop the plantain rounds into the hot oil. Do not fill the entire skillet with the plantain. Fry for 45 seconds. Carefully flip the rounds and fry for 45 seconds more. Continue flipping and frying until the bubbling sound stops. Do not let the plantains brown. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the chips to the paper towel–lined plate

to drain. Immediately season the chips with salt and pepper and toss to coat.

4. Repeat with the remaining plantain rounds.
5. Store the completely cooled chips in an airtight container at room temperature for 3 to 4 days.

PREPARATION TIP: To cut thin slices of plantain, I use the medium-thin setting on my mandoline slicer. If the pieces are too thin, they curl in the oil; thick ones don't crisp.

Pazham Pori | Ripened Banana Fritters

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Pazham pori, *also called* ethakka appam, *is a popular snack from Kerala that is usually served with tea or coffee. Ripe banana slices are dipped in a flour batter and deep-fried. These fritters are very similar to the Indonesian dessert* pisang goreng, *which is simply fried banana.*
SERVES 6

½ cup all-purpose flour

1 tablespoon rice flour

¼ teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon baking soda

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 teaspoon sugar

½ cup water

1½ cups coconut oil

2 ripe nendran bananas, or red bananas, peeled, halved crosswise, and each half cut lengthwise into 3 or 4 pieces

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
2. In a large bowl, whisk the all-purpose flour, rice flour, salt, baking soda, turmeric, and sugar.
3. While whisking, slowly add the water to form a smooth, lump-free batter. It should be thick, but pourable, like pancake batter.
4. In a skillet over medium heat, heat the coconut oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by

dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.

5. Working on 2 or 3 fritters at a time, depending on the size of your skillet, carefully dip a banana slice into the batter and then carefully lower the slice into the hot oil. Do not fill the entire skillet. Fry the bananas for 45 seconds. Using a slotted spoon, carefully flip them and fry for 30 seconds more. Continue flipping and frying until the bubbling sound stops. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the fritters to the paper towel–lined plate to drain.
6. Repeat with the remaining bananas slices and batter.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: If you prefer, instead of coconut oil for frying, use corn or vegetable oil.

Punugulu | Deep-Fried Rice Fritters

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Punugulu *is a popular Andhra snack made with fresh or fermented idli/dosai batter. These fritters are crispy on the outside and soft on the inside. Serve them with Coconut Chutney or Peanut Tamarind Chutney, and, of course, a soothing, fragrant cup of tea.* **SERVES 8**

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1 cup Idli batter or Dosai batter

⅓ cup finely chopped onion

1 tablespoon rice flour

1 tablespoon semolina

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

1 teaspoon finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

½ teaspoon peppercorns

½ teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon baking soda

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1½ cups vegetable or corn oil

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
2. In a wide bowl, stir together the batter, onion, rice flour, semolina, cumin seeds, ginger, peppercorns, salt, baking soda, and asafoetida until thoroughly combined. The batter should be thick.
3. In a medium pot over medium heat, heat the oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by

dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.

4. Using a cookie scoop, slowly and carefully drop 5 or 6 fritters into the hot oil. Do not fill the entire pot. Fry for 30 to 45 seconds. Using a slotted spoon, carefully flip the fritters. Fry for 30 to 45 seconds more. Continue flipping and frying until the bubbling sound stops.
5. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the fritters to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Repeat with the remaining batter.

COOKING TIP: If using a thin, fermented batter to make these, add up to ¼ cup of rice flour. As the fermented batter is slightly sour, the taste of the fritters will differ from those made with fresh batter.

Ulundu Vadais | Soft Lentil Fritters

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 30 to 45 minutes to chill | Cook time: 30 minutes

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These soft donut-shaped lentil fritters are always paired with savory pongal. They are a popular festival food. **SERVES 4**

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1 cup husked whole black lentils, rinsed, soaked in water for 4 to 6 hours, drained

2 green chiles

¼ to ½ cup water

2 teaspoons salt

¼ cup finely chopped onion (optional)

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

10 curry leaves, finely chopped

1 teaspoon finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

1 teaspoon peppercorns

1½ cups corn oil, or vegetable oil

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
2. In a blender, combine the black lentils and green chiles. Adding a little water at a time, pulse the ingredients until a smooth, wet dough forms. Do not use more than ½ cup of water. Transfer the batter to a large bowl and refrigerate for 30 to 45 minutes.
3. Remove the batter from the refrigerator and stir in the salt, onion (if using), cilantro, curry leaves, ginger, and peppercorns.
4. In a deep skillet or wide kadai over medium-high heat, heat the oil. Reduce the heat to medium and heat the oil for 3

minutes. While the oil heats, place the batter next to the stove along with a wide bowl filled with water.

5. When the oil is ready, wet your palms and shake off any excess water. Take a lemon-size portion of batter in your hands and slowly toss it between your palms to form a ball. Holding the ball with your fingers, use your thumb to make a big hole in the center. Make 2 more balls. Carefully drop the vadais into the hot oil and fry for 30 seconds. Using a slotted spoon, flip the vadais and fry for 45 seconds to 1 minute, until they turn light golden brown and the bubbling sound stops. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the vadais to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Repeat with the remaining batter; do not fry more than 3 vadais at a time.

COOKING TIP: Frying in too-hot oil will brown the vadais but the inside might not be cooked well. For soft and crispier vadais, frying at medium heat is best.

Goli Baje | Mangalorean Soft Fritters with Yogurt

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 30 minutes to rest | Cook time: 30 minutes

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Goli baje *is a deep-fried snack from Mangalorean Udupi. It is a soft fritter made with all-purpose flour and yogurt. It is also popularly called Mangalore bajji or Mangalore* bonda. *You can make these delicious fritters with ingredients readily available in a well-stocked pantry.* **SERVES 8**

---

1 green chile

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger

3 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 cup all-purpose flour

2 tablespoons rice flour

2 teaspoons semolina

1 teaspoon sugar

¾ teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon baking soda

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 cup plain Greek yogurt

1½ cups vegetable or corn oil

Chutney of choice, or ketchup, for serving

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.

2. In a blender, combine the green chile, ginger, cilantro, and curry leaves. Pulse to grind coarsely.
3. Sift the all-purpose flour and rice flour into a large bowl. Add the semolina, sugar, salt, baking soda, asafoetida, and the ground herbs. Gently mix to combine.
4. Slowly stir in the yogurt, stirring to form a thick, smooth batter. Let the batter rest for 30 minutes.
5. In a deep skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.
6. Using a cookie scoop, slowly and carefully drop 5 or 6 scoops of batter into the hot oil. Do not fill the skillet. Fry for about 45 seconds. Using a slotted spoon, carefully flip the fitters. Fry for about 30 seconds more. Continue flipping and frying until the fritters turn golden brown or the bubbling sound stops, 90 seconds to 2 minutes.
7. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the goli baje to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Continue with the remaining batter. Serve hot with chutney or ketchup.

COOKING TIP: If the batter is too thick, stir in 1 tablespoon of water; if it is too thin, stir in 1 tablespoon of rice flour. Instead of grinding the herbs, you can finely chop them. I prefer freshly made Greek yogurt that is not sour, but you can also use the slightly sour plain Greek yogurt found in most grocery stores today.

Nippattu | Rice Crackers

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Nippattu *is a crunchy, spicy rice cracker from the state of Karnataka that features flavors of roasted peanuts and chickpeas.* **MAKES 20 CRACKERS**

½ cup idiyappam flour

2½ tablespoons chickpeas, divided

2 tablespoons peanuts

1 tablespoon all-purpose flour

1 tablespoon semolina

1½ teaspoons unsweetened desiccated coconut

1½ teaspoons salt

½ teaspoon red chile powder

½ teaspoon sesame seeds

½ cup water

1½ cups vegetable or corn oil, plus more for greasing

1. Heat a large skillet over medium heat.
2. Add the idiyappam flour and dry-roast lightly for 1 to 2 minutes. Transfer it to a large bowl.
3. Return the skillet to medium heat and add 2 tablespoons of chickpeas. Dry-roast for 2 minutes. Transfer them to another bowl.
4. Return the skillet to medium heat and add the peanuts. Dry-roast for 3 to 4 minutes until lightly browned. Remove from the heat and let cool.

5. Transfer the dry-roasted chickpeas and peanuts to a blender or spice grinder and grind into a coarse mixture. Add this mixture to the bowl with the roasted idiyappam flour.
6. Stir in the all-purpose flour, semolina, remaining ½ tablespoon of chickpeas, coconut, salt, chile powder, and sesame seeds. Slowly stir in the water until a soft pliable dough forms.
7. Pinch off small amounts of dough and form them into small, marble-size balls. Set aside.
8. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
9. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.
10. While the oil heats, coat the inside of a zip-top bag and your palms with oil. Place several dough balls into the bag. Flatten the balls into thin 1½- to 2-inch circles. The edges of the circles might crack. Smooth the round edges as much as possible.
11. When the oil is hot, working in batches of 3 at a time, carefully remove the nippattu from the bag and slowly drop them into the hot oil. Fry for 1 minute. Flip and fry the crackers for 1 minute more. Continue to flip and fry until the bubbling sound stops. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the nippattu to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Repeat pressing and frying the remaining crackers.
12. Let the nippattu cool completely before storing in an airtight container at room temperature for about 1 week.

INGREDIENT TIP: Instead of idiyappam flour, use regular rice flour or any other type of millet flour.

Onion and Mint Pakoda | Onion and Mint Fritters

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Like bajji, pakoda*, or* pakora*, is a popular South Indian street food. You can add veggies such as cauliflower, cabbage, onion, spinach, or nuts to make mixed vegetable pakoda. I keep my version simple with just onion and mint.* **SERVES 6**

½ cup chickpea flour

½ cup rice flour

1 teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon red chile powder

½ teaspoon baking soda

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

20 fresh mint leaves, finely chopped

½ onion, thinly sliced

¼ to ⅓ cup water

1½ cups vegetable or corn oil

1. In a large bowl, sift the chickpea flour and rice flour. Stir in the salt, chile powder, baking soda, turmeric, mint, and onion. Let sit for 10 minutes.
2. A little at a time, stir in the water until a thick, dry dough forms. The dough should not be too moist or watery.
3. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.

4. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.
5. Working in batches of 4 or 5, pinch off small portions (about 1½ tablespoons) of dough and slowly drop them into the hot oil. Fry for 30 to 45 seconds. Using a slotted spoon, slowly flip the pakodas and fry for 30 seconds more. Continue flipping and frying until the bubbling sound stops. Using the slotted spoon, transfer the fritters to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Repeat with the remaining dough.

VARIATION TIP: If using additional vegetables (see headnote) that are high in water content, reduce the amount of water used to make the batter. You can also include fennel powder to add flavor.

Stuffed Eggplant Curry

CHAPTER 7

Vegetable Sides and Mains

A South Indian meal platter is incomplete without vegetable dishes. A festive menu will include at least two vegetable dishes with sambar, rasam, and other stews. Many South Indian recipes use local and seasonal vegetables, including gourds such as bitter gourd, snake gourd, ridge gourd, and ash gourd. Unlike North Indian curries, which are tomato-based, South Indian stews and gravies are tamarind-based.

All these vegetable stir-fries and gravies are low carb. Most are vegan, nut-free, and gluten-free as well. Although the steps might seem numerous, many steps can be done while some ingredients are cooking, saving a lot of time.

Avial | Mixed Vegetable Curry in Yogurt Sauce

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Avial is a delicious mixed vegetable stew in a yogurt-coconut sauce. It is quite popular in Tamil Nadu and Kerala. The Onam festival feast is incomplete without this avial. Here, I share my mother's recipe. You can serve this gravy with rice or with Adai, mixed lentil pancakes. **SERVES 6**

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4 cups mixed chunked vegetables, such as plantain, drumstick, potato, carrot, squash, winter melon, or pumpkin

1¼ cups water, divided

2 teaspoons salt

⅛ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

3 green chiles

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 cup thick yogurt, lightly beaten

2 tablespoons coconut oil

1. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, combine the mixed vegetables, 1 cup of water, salt, and turmeric. Cover and cook for 12 to 15 minutes, until the vegetables are tender yet firm.
2. While the vegetables cook, in a blender, combine the coconut and green chiles. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add the remaining ¼ cup of water until a smooth paste forms.

3. When the vegetables are at the desired firmness, stir in the coconut paste and curry leaves. Reduce the heat to medium and simmer for 5 to 7 minutes.
4. Turn off the heat and stir in the yogurt and coconut oil. Partially cover the skillet with a lid and let the avial sit for 5 to 10 minutes for the flavors to infuse.

INGREDIENT TIP: While you can use a variety of vegetables for this dish, I don't recommend okra, bitter gourd, or radish.

Mixed Vegetable Sambar | Mixed Vegetable Gravy

Prep time: 30 minutes | Cook time: 60 minutes

Sambar—the signature vegetarian dish of South India—is a tamarind-based gravy with vegetables and split pigeon peas. This version is a mixed vegetable sambar with freshly ground sambar masala. Serve it with rice and dry curry, such as Cabbage Palya, Kakarakaya Bellam Vepudu, Potato-Onion Curry, or Ridge Gourd Kootu. **SERVES 8**

½ cup split pigeon peas, rinsed twice in cool water, drained

4½ cups water, divided

1 cherry tomato–size seedless tamarind block, soaked in 1½ cups boiling water for 30 minutes

½ teaspoon corn oil

5 dried Guntur chiles

3 tablespoons coriander seeds

1½ tablespoons Bengal gram

1 onion, roughly chopped, plus 1 extra tablespoon chopped onion (optional)

2 teaspoons husked whole black lentils

1 teaspoon raw sona masoori or ponni rice (optional)

2 teaspoons fenugreek seeds, divided

¼ teaspoon cumin seeds

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 tablespoon coconut oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

1 cup chunked mixed vegetables, such as brinjal, radish, and okra

1 tablespoon salt

1 teaspoon powdered jaggery

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or in a stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the pigeon peas and 2 cups of water.
2. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 20 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 3 to 4 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
3. Carefully unlock and remove the lid and let the pigeon peas cool. Mash the pigeon peas and set aside.
4. Stir the tamarind and the water it has been soaking in. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes as well. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside.
5. In a large skillet or wok over medium heat, heat the corn oil.
6. Add the Guntur chiles, coriander seeds, Bengal gram, extra 1 tablespoon chopped onion (if using), black lentils, raw rice (if using), 1 teaspoon of fenugreek seeds, and the cumin seeds. Dry-roast for 2 to 3 minutes until fragrant, until the lentils turn light brown.

7. Stir in the coconut and dry-roast for 30 seconds. Turn off the heat and let cool. Transfer the mixture to a blender. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add ½ cup of water until a smooth paste forms. Set it aside.
8. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the coconut oil.
9. Add the remaining 1 teaspoon of fenugreek seeds, mustard seeds, curry leaves, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
10. Add the 1 roughly chopped onion and cook for about 5 minutes until the onion is soft and translucent. Add the mixed vegetables and cook for 1 minute.
11. Stir in the tamarind pulp, salt, jaggery, and turmeric. Simmer the mixture for 10 minutes until the vegetables are soft and tender.
12. Stir in the coconut-spice paste and 1 cup of water. Simmer for 3 to 4 minutes.
13. Add the mashed pigeon peas and remaining 1 cup of water. Simmer for 5 minutes. When the sambar starts to boil, turn off the heat.

COOKING TIP: Adding rice while making the masala helps thicken the sambar. You can skip it if you like a thinner consistency, or use the rice and add more water for a thinner consistency.

Ridge Gourd Kootu | Ridge Gourd and Yellow Mung Bean Gravy

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Kootu is a popular Tamil Nadu gravy made with mixed vegetables, or one vegetable and yellow split mung beans, and freshly ground coconut paste. This non-tamarind gravy is served as a side. I prefer it with plain white rice and a dollop of ghee. Kootu is quite easy to make and it's my go-to weekday recipe. I am sharing my son's favorite kootu, made with ridge gourd. Serve this dish with rice or as a side with rice and Mixed Vegetable Sambar. **SERVES 6**

---

4 cups cubed (2-inch pieces) peeled ridge gourd

¼ cup split yellow mung beans, rinsed well and drained

1½ cups water

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

2 dried Guntur chiles

1 tablespoon finely chopped peeled fresh ginger

1 tablespoon coconut oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon Bengal gram

½ teaspoon husked whole black lentils

1 curry leaf sprig

1½ teaspoons salt

1 tablespoon fresh cilantro

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or in a stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the gourd, mung beans, water, and turmeric.
2. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 8 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 3 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
3. While the gourd and mung beans cook, in a blender, combine the coconut, cumin seeds, Guntur chiles, and ginger and grind into a coarse paste.
4. In a large skillet or wok over medium heat, heat the coconut oil.
5. Add the mustard seeds, Bengal gram, black lentils, and curry leaves. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
6. Add the cooked gourd and mung beans and salt to the skillet. Simmer for 3 to 4 minutes.
7. Add the ground coconut-spice paste and cilantro to the skillet and mix thoroughly. Bring it to a boil and then turn off the heat.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of ridge gourd, you can use bottle gourd, chayote squash, snake gourd, winter melon, or ash gourd.

Kosambari | Lentil and Vegetable Salad

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 1 hour to soak | Cook time: 10 minutes

Kosambari, *or* kosumalli, *is a light, crunchy, refreshing salad made with soaked lentils and shredded vegetables. This easy salad is a must for festival feasts.* **SERVES 6**

¼ cup split yellow mung beans, rinsed twice with cool water, drained

¼ cup Bengal gram, rinsed twice with cool water, drained

2 cups water

¼ cup shredded carrot

¼ cup shredded cucumber

¼ cup shredded raw mango (optional)

1 teaspoon corn oil

2 teaspoons mustard seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 green chile, finely chopped

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

1 teaspoon salt

2 teaspoons freshly squeezed lemon juice, or lime juice

1. In a medium bowl, combine the mung beans, Bengal gram, and water. Let soak for 1 hour. Drain well and transfer to a large bowl.
2. Add the carrot, cucumber, and mango (if using) to the bowl and toss to combine with the mung beans and Bengal gram.
3. In a medium skillet over medium heat, heat the oil.

4. Reduce the heat to medium-low and add the mustard seeds, asafoetida, and green chile. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Add this spice mixture to the salad. Stir to combine.
5. Just before serving, add the salt and lemon juice. Stir to combine and serve at room temperature.

COOKING TIP: During summer months, add shredded mango when it's in season. You can also include shredded coconut and finely chopped bell pepper.

Erissery | Plantain and Yam Curry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 25 minutes

Erissery *is a traditional recipe from Kerala and, like Avial, is a must for the Onam Sadya feast. Usually, erissery, or* yeriserry*, is made with pumpkin. This recipe is my mother's and it uses plantain and yam. The freshly ground paste is made with coconut and black pepper. Serve this dish with rice.* **SERVES 6**

---

2 cups cubed plantain

1 cup cubed yam

1 cup water

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 teaspoon salt

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 tablespoon peppercorns

¼ teaspoon cumin seeds

1 tablespoon coconut oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

1. In a medium pot over medium-high heat, combine the plantain, yam, water, turmeric, and salt. Cover the pot and cook for 8 to 10 minutes until the vegetables are soft and tender.
2. While the vegetables cook, in a blender, combine the coconut, peppercorns, and cumin seeds and grind into a coarse paste.

3. When the vegetables are soft and tender, add the coconut-spice paste and mix well. Cook for 5 minutes and turn off the heat.
4. In a small skillet over medium heat, heat the oil.
5. Add the mustard seeds and curry leaves and cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Stir this spice mixture into the vegetables until mixed well.

INGREDIENT TIP: You can use just yam or just plantain for this recipe. Or use 2 cups of the vegetables and plantain and add 1 cup cooked black-eyed peas.

Cabbage Palya | Green Cabbage and Coconut Stir-Fry

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Stir-fries are quite popular in South Indian cuisine. In Tamil they are known as poriyal*; in Karnataka, as palya; in Telugu, as* vepudu*; and in Malayalam, as* thoran*. Vegetable stir-fries are sometimes shallow-fried vegetables with onion, or steamed vegetables tempered with coconut and other spices. This mild cabbage stir-fry with coconut is a perfect side for any variety of rice, sambar, or Tomato Rasam or a* pulusu*.* **SERVES 8**

---

2 tablespoons corn oil

1½ teaspoons mustard seeds

1½ teaspoons husked whole black lentils

1½ teaspoons Bengal gram

4 green chiles, finely chopped

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 green cabbage, shredded (about 10 cups)

1 tablespoon salt

½ teaspoon ground turmeric (optional)

1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 (2-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and roughly chopped

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the oil.
2. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, and Bengal gram. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.

3. Add the green chiles and curry leaves and cook for 30 seconds.
4. Add the cabbage, salt, and turmeric (if using), and mix thoroughly. Cover the skillet and cook for 12 minutes. Remove the lid and increase the heat to medium-high. Cook for 10 to 12 minutes more until all the moisture has evaporated.
5. While the cabbage cooks, in a blender, combine the coconut and ginger and grind until coarse. Add this to the cabbage once the moisture is evaporated and mix well. Cook for 1 minute. Turn off the heat and stir in the cilantro.

INGREDIENT TIP: You can make a similar stir-fry with green beans, cluster beans, white radish, carrots, and beets.

Vegetable Sagu | Mixed Vegetable Curry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Vegetable sagu is a popular Karnataka dish similar to a mixed vegetable kurma. *The freshly ground masala, coconut, and roasted split chickpeas make this sagu creamy and delicious. Traditionally served with Dosai and poori (unleavened deep-fried flatbread), it pairs well with Idli and other flatbreads.* **SERVES 4**

---

2 teaspoons corn oil

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 onion, finely chopped

2 cups chunked mixed vegetables, such as cauliflower, peas, beans, carrots, potatoes, zucchini

2½ to 3 cups water, divided

1½ teaspoons salt

3 tablespoons roasted split chickpeas

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

3 whole cloves

1 (2-inch) cinnamon stick

3 green cardamom pods

1 teaspoon peppercorns

3 green chiles

1 teaspoon poppy seeds

2 garlic cloves

5 fresh mint leaves

4 tablespoons chopped fresh cilantro, divided

1. In a large skillet or wok over medium heat, heat the oil.
2. Add the cumin seeds and curry leaves. Cook for 30 seconds.
3. Add the onion and cook for 5 minutes, or until the onion is soft and translucent.
4. Add the mixed vegetables, 1 cup of water, and the salt. Cover the skillet and cook for 8 to 10 minutes, until the vegetables are soft and tender.
5. In a blender, combine the roasted split chickpeas, coconut, cloves, cinnamon, cardamom, peppercorns, green chiles, poppy seeds, garlic, mint, and 2 tablespoons of the cilantro. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add ½ cup of water until a smooth paste forms. Transfer the masala to a bowl. Rinse the blender with ½ cup of water and set aside (do not discard).
6. Once the vegetables are soft and tender, add the masala paste and the water used to rinse the blender to the skillet. Mix well. Simmer for 5 to 7 minutes, or until the raw smell of the paste is gone. If you prefer a thinner consistency, add ½ to 1 cup of water and bring it to a boil. If not, turn off the heat and stir in the remaining 2 tablespoons of cilantro.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of roasted chickpeas, use 10 whole cashews.

Kakarakaya Bellam Vepudu | Bitter Gourd Jaggery Stir-Fry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

If you are wondering how to incorporate bitter gourd into your everyday cooking, this Andhra/Telangana–style bitter gourd jaggery is the perfect answer. Kakarakaya *means "bitter gourd" and* bellam *means "jaggery." The jaggery and spice balance the bitterness of the bitter gourd and make this curry delectable. Serve it with rice.* **SERVES 6**

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3 cups chopped (1-inch pieces) bitter gourd

3 cups water

3 tablespoons corn oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

½ cup finely chopped onion

1 teaspoon red chile powder

2 teaspoons ground coriander

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

2 teaspoons salt

3 tablespoons powdered jaggery

1. In a large microwave-safe bowl, combine the bitter gourd and water. Microwave on high, uncovered, for 10 to 12 minutes, or until the bitter gourd is soft and tender. Drain and set aside.
2. In a large skillet or kadai over medium heat, heat the oil.

3. Add the mustard seeds and cumin seeds and cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the onion and cook for about 5 minutes, until the onion is translucent.
5. Stir in the chile powder, coriander, turmeric, and salt.
6. Add the bitter gourd and mix thoroughly. Cook for 3 to 4 minutes, or until the moisture is evaporated.
7. Stir in the jaggery. It will create more liquid. Cook until it is evaporated, 2 to 3 minutes, and turn off the heat.

COOKING TIP: To cook the bitter gourd on the stovetop, bring 3 cups of water to a rolling boil over high heat and add the bitter gourd. Cook for 7 to 8 minutes; turn off the heat, and drain.

Soppu Saaru | Spinach and Lentil Gravy

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 60 minutes

Soppu saaru *is a dish from Karnataka. A spinach and lentil gravy prepared with split pigeon peas and mixed greens, it is usually served with Ragi Mudde or rice. Another way to enjoy this protein- and nutrient-packed dish is to savor it like a stew with roti.* **SERVES 6**

½ cup split pigeon peas, rinsed well in cool water, drained

2½ cups water, divided

1 tablespoon rasam powder

1½ tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 tablespoon vegetable or corn oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

½ cup finely chopped onion

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

2 green chiles, slit lengthwise

2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh dill (see Ingredient Tip)

3 cups packed mixed greens, such as spinach and beet greens

2 teaspoons tamarind paste

1 teaspoon powdered jaggery

2 teaspoons salt

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the pigeon peas and 1½ cups of water.

2. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select the Bean/Chili function and set the time to 30 minutes (or select Manual and cook for at least 20 minutes on High Pressure). Let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium-high heat and put the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 3 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
3. Carefully unlock and remove the lid and let the pigeon peas cool. Transfer them to a medium bowl and mash them with a potato masher. Set aside. Wash the pressure cooker pot.
4. In a blender, combine the rasam powder and coconut. Pulse a few times to grind. With the blender running, slowly add the remaining 1 cup of water until a smooth paste forms. Set aside.
5. On your electric pressure cooker, select Sauté or place a stovetop pressure cooker over medium heat, and heat the vegetable oil.
6. Add the mustard seeds, cumin seeds, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
7. Add the onion, garlic, and green chiles. Cook for about 5 minutes, or until the onion is translucent.
8. Add the dill, mixed greens, tamarind paste, jaggery, salt, and coconut paste and stir until mixed well. Cook for 2 minutes. Stir in the split pigeon peas.
9. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Cancel, then Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 10 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 2 times. Let the pressure release naturally.

10. Carefully unlock and remove the lid. Mash the mixture with a potato masher.

INGREDIENT TIP: Instead of mixed greens, use 3 cups baby or regular spinach. I usually use a combination of beet greens, spinach, and dill. Dill adds a strong flavor; reduce it to 1 tablespoon if you prefer.

Tomato Rasam | Tomato Soup

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Rasam is a thin South Indian soup made with or without lentils. Enjoy this tomato rasam as a soup or with rice. **SERVES 4**

FOR THE RASAM POWDER

1½ cups coriander seeds

6 or 7 dried Guntur chiles

½ cup split pigeon peas

½ cup plus 1 teaspoon cumin seeds, divided

½ cup peppercorns

2 tablespoons ground turmeric

FOR THE SOUP

2 Roma tomatoes, finely chopped

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

2 garlic cloves, peeled and crushed

4 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro, divided

2 curry leaf sprigs

2 teaspoons salt

3 cups water

2 teaspoons ghee

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

¼ teaspoon asafoetida

TO MAKE THE RASAM POWDER

1. Heat a large skillet over medium heat.

2. Add the coriander seeds, Guntur chiles, pigeon peas, ½ cup of the cumin seeds, and the peppercorns. Dry-roast for 4 to 5 minutes until the pigeon peas turn light brown. Turn off the heat and let cool.
3. Transfer the spice mixture to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a coarse powder. Transfer to a storage container and stir in the turmeric.

TO MAKE THE SOUP

1. In a medium saucepan over medium heat, combine 1 tablespoon of rasam powder, the tomatoes, tamarind paste, garlic, 2 tablespoons of cilantro, curry leaves, salt, and water. Stir until mixed well. Simmer for 5 minutes. Using the back of a ladle, mash the tomatoes. Continue to simmer for 2 to 5 minutes more until the rasam becomes frothy on top. Turn off the heat.
2. In a small skillet over medium heat, melt the ghee. Add the mustard seeds, remaining 1 teaspoon of cumin seeds, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute. Turn off the heat. Add this spice mixture to the soup and stir until mixed well.
3. Stir in the remaining 2 tablespoons of cilantro. Partially cover the saucepan and let sit for 5 minutes for the flavors to infuse.

Bangaladumpa Ullipaya Vepudu | Potato-Onion Curry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

This Andhra-style spicy curry made with bangaladumpa *(potato) and* ullipaya *(onion) pairs well with any rice dish. You can stuff the curry inside Dosai to make masala dosa.* **SERVES 6**

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6 cups water

2 teaspoons salt, divided

1 pound Yukon Gold potatoes (6 medium potatoes)

2½ tablespoons vegetable or corn oil, divided

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon husked whole black lentils

½ teaspoon Bengal gram

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 onion, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground coriander

1. In a large pot over high heat, combine the water, 1 teaspoon of salt, and the potatoes and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to medium and cook for 15 to 17 minutes, until the potatoes are tender, but firm. Drain immediately and let the potatoes cool. Peel and cut into cubes.
2. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat 1½ tablespoons of oil.

3. Add the mustard seeds, black lentils, and Bengal gram. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the curry leaves and cook for 30 seconds.
5. Add the onion and garlic and cook for about 5 minutes, until the onion is translucent.
6. Stir in the chile powder, coriander, and remaining 1 teaspoon of salt. Cook for 2 minutes.
7. Add the potatoes to the skillet and gently mix. Reduce the heat to medium-low and roast the potatoes for 7 to 8 minutes, turning them every minute, until they turn light brown. If the skillet becomes too dry, add the remaining 1 tablespoon of oil.

COOKING TIP: You can make this curry without the onion and garlic. After frying the curry leaves, add the chile powder, coriander, and salt and fry for 1 minute. Then add ¼ cup of water and stir to blend. Add the cubed potatoes and roast until the potatoes turn nice and crisp.

Gutti Vankaya Koora | Stuffed Eggplant Curry

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

If you like spicy curry, this recipe made with the small Indian eggplant is for you. Although the ingredient list is lengthy, the curry is easy to make. The fresh masala powder is prepared by roasting the spices and then stuffing them into the eggplants, which are cooked in a simple onion gravy. This curry pairs perfectly with Ragi Mudde as well as plain steamed rice. **SERVES 6**

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6 small eggplant (brinjal), cut diagonally twice (in an X), almost all the way through, but leaving the stalk intact

4 tablespoons plus 1 teaspoon corn oil, divided

3 tablespoons peanuts

1 tablespoon poppy seeds

1 tablespoon sesame seeds

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

4 dried Guntur chiles

4 whole cloves

4 green cardamom pods

1 tablespoon coriander seeds

1½ teaspoons cumin seeds

1 (1½-inch) cinnamon stick

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 onion, finely chopped

2 teaspoons ginger-garlic paste

1 tablespoon salt

2 teaspoons tamarind paste

1 teaspoon red chile powder

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

½ teaspoon garam masala

1½ cups water

1 tablespoon finely chopped fresh cilantro

1. In a large bowl, combine the eggplants with enough water to cover.
2. In a large skillet, or wok, over medium heat, heat 1 teaspoon of oil.
3. Add the peanuts, poppy seeds, sesame seeds, and coconut. Cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until the peanuts and sesame seeds are light brown. Transfer to a dish and set aside.
4. Return the skillet to the heat and add the Guntur chiles, cloves, cardamom, coriander seeds, cumin seeds, and cinnamon. Cook for 2 minutes, until fragrant and the red chiles are slightly darkened. Turn off the heat and let cool.
5. Transfer the peanut and coconut mixture and spices to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a coarse powder. Set aside.
6. Drain the eggplants. Stuff 1 tablespoon of the spice mix inside the slits of each eggplant.
7. Wipe out the skillet, place it over medium heat, and heat 1 tablespoon of oil.
8. Add the eggplants to the skillet and roast for about 5 minutes, carefully turning them every minute, until they are softened. Transfer the eggplants to a plate.
9. Return the skillet to the heat and heat the remaining 3 tablespoons of oil.

10. Add the mustard seeds and cook until they begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
11. Add the curry leaves and cook for 30 seconds.
12. Stir in the onion and ginger-garlic paste and cook for about 5 minutes, until the onion is translucent.
13. Add the salt, tamarind paste, chile powder, turmeric, garam masala, and remaining spice powder. Stir until mixed well and cook for 3 minutes. The oil will slowly separate.
14. Add the water and the eggplants to the skillet. Cover the skillet and cook for 5 minutes. Remove the lid, reduce the heat to medium-low, and cook for 5 to 7 minutes more, until the oil separates and floats to the top. Turn off the heat and stir in the cilantro.

COOKING TIP: You can skip stuffing the brinjals (eggplant) and, instead, chop them lengthwise and add to the curry. You can make dry curry by using just ½ cup of water. Cover and cook until the brinjals are soft and tender. Remove the lid and cook until all the moisture is evaporated.

Bendakaya Ullipaya Pulusu | Okra and Onion Tamarind Stew

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Pulusu is an Andhra/Telangana–style spicy and tangy tamarind gravy or stew. I love pulusu on rice mixed with a dollop of sesame oil, which balances the spices. You can make pulusu with any vegetable, but okra and shallots are popular—and my favorite combination! **SERVES 6**

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2 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

1 teaspoon fenugreek seeds

½ teaspoon asafoetida

1 green chile, slit lengthwise

2 curry leaf sprigs

10 shallots, peeled

1½ teaspoons ginger-garlic paste

3 okra, cut crosswise into 2-inch slices

1 tomato, finely chopped

1½ teaspoons salt

2 teaspoons red chile powder

1½ tablespoons tamarind paste

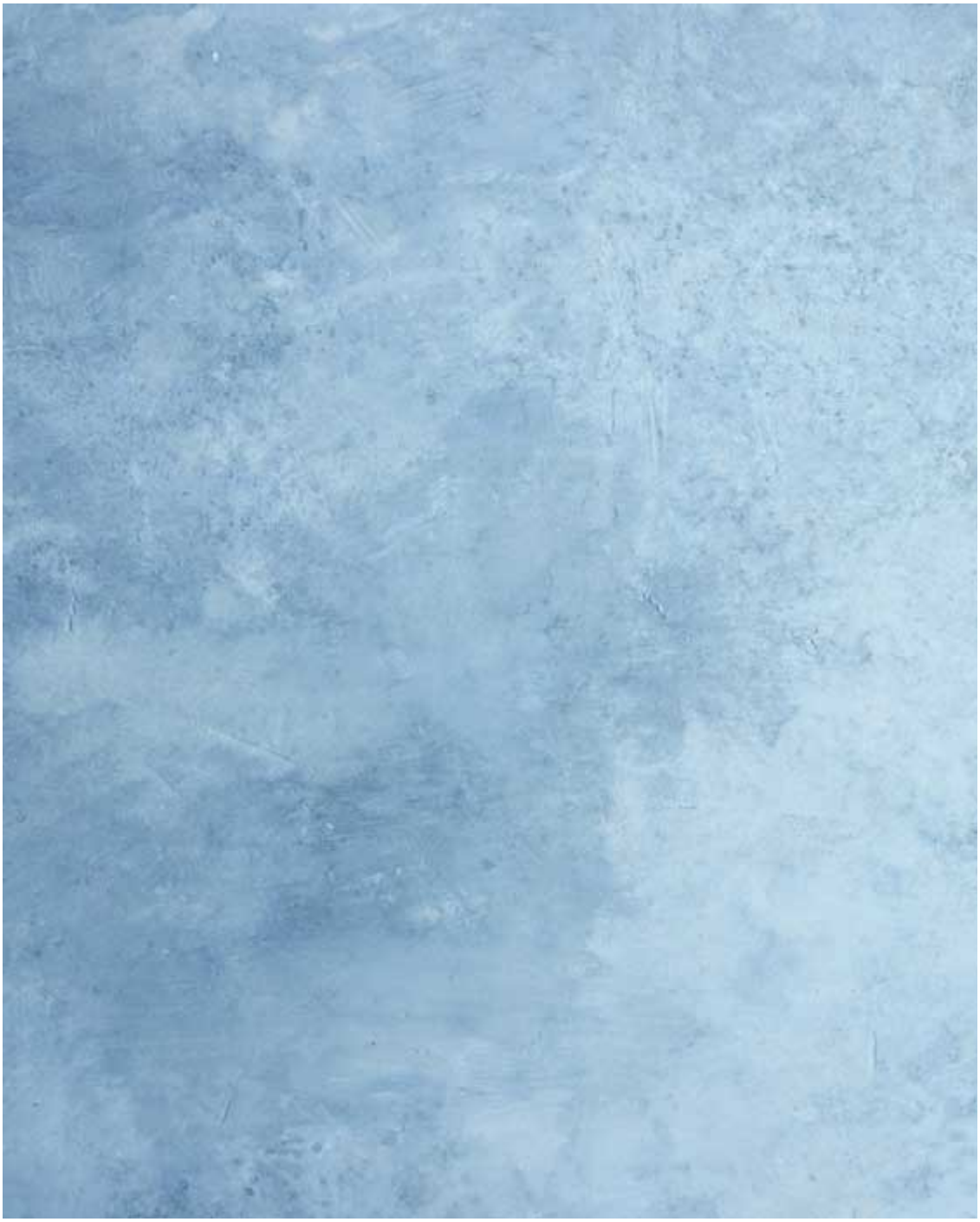
2½ cups water, divided

1 teaspoon rice flour (optional)

1. In a large skillet or wok over medium heat, heat the oil.
2. Add the mustard seeds, fenugreek seeds, and asafoetida. Cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.

3. Add the green chile and the curry leaves. Cook for 30 seconds.
4. Add the shallots and ginger-garlic paste and cook for 3 to 4 minutes, until the shallots no longer smell raw.
5. Add the okra and cook for 3 minutes more.
6. Stir in the tomato, salt, and chile powder. Sauté for 5 minutes, until the tomato is soft and broken down.
7. Add the tamarind paste and 2 cups of water and stir until mixed well. Reduce the heat to medium-low and simmer for 15 minutes.
8. If you prefer a thinner gravy, skip this step. For a thicker gravy, in a small bowl, whisk the rice flour and remaining ½ cup of water. Stir this paste into the pulusu and simmer for 5 minutes. Turn off the heat.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of shallots, use 1 large red onion, finely chopped (about 1 cup).



Malabar-Style Prawn Soup

CHAPTER 8

Fish and Seafood

Prawns, shrimp, crabs, freshwater fish, and saltwater fish are integral to South Indian cuisine. Indian salmon, pearl spot fish, sardines, mackerel, anchovies, pomfret, kingfish—all make some truly delicious South Indian dishes. The beaches in South India host street food stalls, and you can find a variety of fish fries and curries, not to mention crab and prawn roasts, marinated and steamed fish, shredded fish, and fish stews. Most of these dishes are served with rice.

Meen Pollichathu | Fried Fish in Banana Leaf

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 10 minutes to rest | Cook time: 30 minutes

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Meen pollichathu *is a delicious treat from Kerala, and it is a favorite dish on* kettuvellam*—the slow-moving boats that make leisure trips around the backwaters of Kerala. Meen pollichathu is fish coated with spicy masala that is then wrapped in a banana leaf and pan-fried. The banana leaf infuses a distinct flavor and makes this dish delicious.* **SERVES 4**

FOR THE FISH

1 teaspoon red chile powder

½ teaspoon ground coriander

½ teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

4 (4- to-6-ounce) fish fillets, such as tilapia, cod, or pomfret

1 tablespoon coconut oil

FOR THE MASALA

1 tablespoon coconut oil

2 onions, chopped

2 curry leaf sprigs

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

2 tomatoes, chopped

1 green chile, minced

1 teaspoon red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground coriander

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

Salt

2 tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

2 cilantro sprigs, roughly chopped

FOR PREPARING

1 banana leaf (about 36 inches long), cut into 4 pieces

Coconut oil, for greasing

1 curry leaf sprig

Vegetable or corn oil, for cooking

2 limes, cut into wedges

TO MAKE THE FISH

1. In a small bowl, stir together the chile powder, coriander, salt, pepper, and turmeric. Spread this spice blend over both sides of each fish fillet. Let rest for 10 minutes.
2. In a large pan over medium heat, heat the coconut oil. Add the fillets and fry for 2 to 3 minutes per side, until lightly browned and nearly cooked through. Transfer the fish to a plate and set aside.

TO MAKE THE MASALA

1. In the same pan over medium-high heat, heat the coconut oil. Add the onions, curry leaves, garlic, and ginger. Cook for 5 to 7 minutes, until the onions are translucent.
2. Stir in the tomatoes, green chile, chile powder, coriander, and turmeric and season with salt. Cook for 3 to 5 minutes, stirring frequently, until the tomatoes are softened and broken down.
3. Add the coconut and cilantro and cook for 2 minutes more.

4. Add the cooked fish to the masala. Spoon the masala over the fish and gently stir the sauce to prevent scorching, being careful not to break apart the fillets.

TO PREPARE THE DISH

1. Heat a banana leaf piece over one of your stove's burners to soften it until it bends easily. Lightly grease the leaf on one side with coconut oil.
2. Sprinkle some of the curry leaves over the banana leaf. Add some of the masala to the banana leaf, then place one of the fish fillets on it. Cover the fillet with more masala so both sides of the fish are coated. Repeat with the remaining banana leaves and fish.
3. Wrap two opposite sides of the banana leaf inward, over the fish, and then wrap the other two sides inward to close the package. Tie the leaf shut using kitchen twine. Repeat with the remaining banana leaves.
4. In a large skillet over low heat, heat 1 tablespoon of vegetable oil. Place the banana leaf–wrapped fish in the skillet. Cover and cook for 5 minutes. Flip and cook on the other side for 5 minutes.
5. Transfer to a plate and unwrap the fish at the table. Serve with lime wedges for squeezing.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: If you don't have access to banana leaves, wrap the fish in aluminum foil instead. The fish can also be served family style, wrapping the fillets in one large banana leaf (or foil piece) before cooking.

Fish Pulusu | Andhra Fish Curry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 45 minutes

Most South Indian stews are tamarind-based, making them tangy and spicy. But when served with rice and a dollop of ghee or sesame oil, the flavors are well balanced. This easy-to-make fish curry is from Telugu, and it can be prepared with tilapia, catfish, or mackerel. Be sure to prepare extra for the next day, because the fish will soak up even more flavor from the curry overnight. **SERVES 4**

⅓ cup seedless tamarind block, soaked in 2 cups boiling water for 30 minutes

3 tomatoes

¼ cup vegetable oil

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

Pinch fenugreek seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 onion, chopped

2 green chiles, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground cumin

1 teaspoon ground coriander

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 pound boneless, skinless fish fillets, such as tilapia, catfish, or mackerel

1 teaspoon salt

Chopped fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish (optional)

1. Stir the tamarind and the water it has been soaking in. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes as well. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside.
2. In a blender or food processor, purée the tomatoes. Set aside.
3. In a large pot over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil. Add the mustard seeds and fenugreek seeds and cook until they begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Stir in the curry leaves.
5. Add the onion and green chiles. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes until the onion is transluscent.
6. Add the garlic and ginger and cook for 1 to 2 minutes, until fragrant.
7. Stir in the tomatoes and tamarind pulp, followed by the chile powder, cumin, coriander, pepper, and turmeric. Bring the mixture to a boil. Reduce the heat to maintain a simmer and cook for 20 minutes, stirring occasionally.
8. Carefully lower the fish fillets onto the curry. Cover and cook for 2 to 3 minutes. Flip the fillets and cook for 5 to 10 minutes more, until the fish is cooked through and the oil begins to separate and rise to the top. Season with salt and garnish with cilantro (if using).

SERVING TIP: Serve this curry with rice.

Andhra-Style Prawn Fry

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 15 minutes

The prawn fry is popularly known as royalla vepudu *in Telugu. This dry prawn curry can be served as a starter, or with rice for an entrée. The shrimp are marinated, pan-roasted with curry leaves, and impossible to resist!* **SERVES 4**

1 pound shrimp, peeled and deveined
2 garlic cloves, minced, divided
1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced, divided
1 teaspoon ground coriander, divided
1 teaspoon ground cumin, divided
1 teaspoon red chile powder, divided
½ teaspoon ground turmeric, divided
½ teaspoon salt, plus more for seasoning
1 large onion, coarsely chopped
2 tablespoons vegetable oil
1 green chile, finely chopped
2 curry leaf sprigs
1 teaspoon garam masala
Fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. In a medium bowl, combine the shrimp, half the garlic, half the ginger, $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon of coriander, $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon of cumin, $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon of chile powder, and $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon of turmeric. Lightly season with salt. Set aside.

2. In a blender or food processor, pulse the onion several times until a chunky paste forms.
3. Heat a large skillet over medium-low heat.
4. Add the marinated shrimp to the skillet in a single layer and cook for 4 to 5 minutes, until they are cooked through and all the water released from the shrimp has evaporated. Remove the shrimp and set aside.
5. Increase the heat to medium and add the vegetable oil to the skillet.
6. Add the onion paste and green chile and cook for 3 to 5 minutes, stirring frequently, until lightly browned.
7. Add the remaining garlic and ginger and cook for 30 seconds.
8. Stir in the salt and the remaining spices: ½ teaspoon of coriander, ½ teaspoon of cumin, ½ teaspoon of chile powder, and ¼ teaspoon of turmeric. Add 1 to 2 tablespoons of water to the pan to prevent the spices from scorching.
9. Add the cooked shrimp and curry leaves to the skillet and cook, stirring constantly, for about 2 minutes.
10. Remove the skillet from the heat and stir in the garam masala. Garnish with cilantro.

COOKING TIP: Be sure to cook the shrimp on medium-low to cook them through without scorching. Because they will release some water as they cook, there is no need to add any oil to the pan when you cook the shrimp.

Fish Molee | Kerala-Style Fish Stew

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 15 minutes to rest | Cook time: 15 minutes

---

Molee is a Kerala-style fish stew with coconut milk. Fish molee is a Portuguese-influenced mild stew made with cardamom, cloves, cinnamon, and coconut milk. Use tilapia, pomfret, or cod for this stew.
SERVES 4

---

1 pound fish fillets, such as tilapia, pomfret, or cod
1 teaspoon ground turmeric
1 teaspoon salt
2 tablespoons freshly squeezed lemon juice, divided
2 tablespoons coconut oil, divided
1 (15-ounce) can full-fat coconut milk (do not shake)
2 green cardamom pods
2 whole cloves
1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick
1 onion, sliced
2 green chiles, slit lengthwise
3 curry leaf sprigs
3 garlic cloves, minced
1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced
1 tomato, sliced
1 teaspoon red chile powder
½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

1. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.

2. Place the fish in a large bowl and sprinkle it with turmeric, salt, and 1 tablespoon of lemon juice. Set aside for 15 minutes.
3. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat 1 tablespoon of coconut oil.
4. Add the fish and cook for 1 minute per side until lightly fried but not cooked through. Remove the fish from the skillet and set aside on the paper towel–lined plate to drain.
5. Open the can of coconut milk and separate the thick cream from the thinner liquid. Set aside.
6. Wipe the skillet clean, place it over medium-high heat, and heat the remaining 1 tablespoon of coconut oil.
7. Add the cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon. Cook, stirring, for a few seconds, until fragrant.
8. Add the onion, green chiles, and curry leaves and cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onion is transluscent.
9. Add the garlic and ginger to the skillet and cook for 30 seconds, until fragrant.
10. Add the tomato and chile powder and cook for about 1 minute, gently stirring so as not to break up the tomato.
11. Stir in the thinner coconut milk and the pepper, mixing well.
12. Gently lower the fish pieces on top of the curry and simmer for 5 to 6 minutes, until they are cooked through.
13. Add the thicker coconut cream to the top of curry, reduce the heat to low, and let it melt into the curry. Gently stir it into the sauce without breaking up the fish.
14. Stir in the remaining 1 tablespoon of lemon juice. Taste and season with salt, if needed, and serve.

SERVING TIP: Serve the curry hot alongside rice, Dosai, chapati, or Appam.

South Indian-Style Crab Masala

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 35 minutes

Crab masala is a popular takeout order because cleaning crab can be time consuming. This homemade version is so easy to make that it is worth all the time it takes to clean the crabs. Serve it with rice and with tiffin recipes like Idli, Dosai, Appam, and idiyappam. **SERVES 4**

4 small Dungeness crabs, halved lengthwise

2 teaspoons coriander seeds

1 teaspoon peppercorns

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon fennel seeds

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

2 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

1 onion, chopped

1 curry leaf sprig

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

1 green chile, minced

2 tomatoes, chopped

2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 teaspoon salt

1. Clean the crabs well (see Cooking tip) and set aside.
2. In a large skillet over medium heat, combine the coriander seeds, peppercorns, cumin seeds, fennel seeds, and coconut.

Dry-roast for 1 to 2 minutes, stirring frequently, until fragrant. Transfer the spices and coconut to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.

3. Return the skillet to medium-high heat and add the oil. When the oil is heated, add the mustard seeds. Cook until the seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the onion and curry leaves and cook for 5 to 6 minutes, until the onion is transluscent.
5. Add the garlic, ginger, and green chile and cook for 30 seconds.
6. Add the tomatoes and cook until they begin to soften. Transfer the mixer to a blender and purée until smooth and combined. Return the mixture to the skillet and place it over medium-low heat.
7. Stir in the coconut-spice mixture and chile powder. Simmer for about 5 minutes, until the oil begins to separate and float on top.
8. Place the crabs on top of the masala and season with salt. Cover the skillet and cook for 5 minutes. Remove the lid and spoon some of the sauce over the crabs. Re-cover the skillet and cook for about 10 minutes more, periodically spooning some sauce over the crabs. Serve hot.

COOKING TIP: Be sure to clean the crabs well by washing each several times in cool water. Remove the gills and all the intestinal parts once you cut the crabs in half. Anything that is not pure white is not meat, and can be removed.

South Indian-Style Fish Fry

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 30 minutes to marinate | Cook time: 6 minutes

---

For a seafood lover, a beach trip is incomplete without some fish fry from a food stall. The style and taste of the fish fry vary depending on the region. This recipe is one version you can quickly make at home with minimal ingredients. **SERVES 4**

---

2 garlic cloves, finely minced

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely minced

1 to 2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 pound fish fillets, such as tilapia, sole, or pomfret

2 tablespoons vegetable or corn oil

Sliced red onion, for serving

Lime wedges, for serving

1. In a small bowl, stir together the garlic, ginger, chile powder, salt, and turmeric.
2. Spread the spice mixture over the fillets and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes, or up to 2 hours.
3. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat the vegetable oil.
4. Add the fish and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until the fillets become opaque around the edges. Flip and cook for 2 to 3 more minutes more, until cooked through. (If cooking the fish in

batches, you will need to heat more oil in the skillet before cooking the second batch.)

5. Serve with the red onion slices and lime wedges for squeezing over the fillets.

COOKING TIP: To check for doneness, use a fork to gently pierce a piece of the fish. When done, it should easily pierce and flake. Be careful not to overcook the fish, as it can become tough and the spices can burn.

Kerala-Style Prawn Masala Roast

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 15 minutes

Popularly known as nadan chemmeen *roast in Kerala, this country-style prawn masala roast made with fresh spices, coconut, and coconut oil is a great complement to rice. You can replace the shrimp with fish if you prefer.* **SERVES 4**

2 onions, chopped, divided

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled

1 curry leaf sprig

1 green chile, stemmed and seeded

1 tablespoon coconut oil

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

½ teaspoon fennel seeds

¼ teaspoon fenugreek seeds

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 to 2 teaspoons red chile powder

½ teaspoon ground coriander

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

Salt

1 pound shrimp, peeled and deveined

1 teaspoon garam masala

Chopped fresh cilantro, for garnish

1. In a blender, combine half the onion, the ginger, curry leaves, and green chile and process until smooth. Set aside.

2. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat the coconut oil.
3. Add the mustard seeds and cook until they begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Stir in the fennel seeds and fenugreek seeds. Add the puréed mixture to the skillet and cook for about 1 minute, stirring constantly.
5. Add the remaining chopped onion and the garlic. Cook for 4 to 5 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onion is translucent.
6. Add the chile powder, coriander, pepper, and turmeric. Season with salt and stir.
7. Add the shrimp to the skillet and stir to combine. Cover the skillet and reduce the heat to low. Cook for 5 to 7 minutes until the shrimp are opaque and cooked through.
8. Remove the lid and stir in the garam masala. Top with cilantro for serving.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: If you prefer a less spicy dish, instead of chopping the green chile, leave it whole and slit it lengthwise. Cook it with the garlic and onion in step 6. The finished dish will get some of the heat without having pieces of chile in every bite.

Eral Thokku | Tamil Nadu–Style Prawn Gravy

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 1 hour to marinate | Cook time: 20 minutes

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Eral *means "prawns" in Tamil. This delicious semi-dry prawn curry is an excellent side for a variety of rice dishes. It also makes a perfect accompaniment to a nonvegetarian platter. The prawns are marinated and cooked with onion and tomato, and the fennel seeds add a distinct flavor to this dish—take care not to burn them.* **SERVES 4**

---

1 pound shrimp, peeled and deveined

½ teaspoon ground turmeric, divided

Salt

1 tablespoon vegetable oil

1 onion, chopped

1 teaspoon fennel seeds

1 curry leaf sprig

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely minced

2 tomatoes, finely chopped

1 to 2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 tablespoon ground coriander

¼ cup water

Chopped fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. In a small bowl, combine the shrimp and ¼ teaspoon of turmeric. Season with salt and mix well. Refrigerate to marinate for about 1 hour.

2. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat the vegetable oil.
3. Add the onion, fennel seeds, and curry leaves to the skillet. Lightly season with salt and cook, stirring frequently, for 5 to 6 minutes until the onion is translucent.
4. Stir in the garlic and ginger and cook for about 20 seconds, just until fragrant.
5. Add the tomatoes and a bit more salt. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until the tomatoes are broken down and cooked.
6. Stir in the chile powder, coriander, and remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon of turmeric. Season with salt.
7. Add the marinated shrimp and water to the skillet and stir to coat the shrimp. Cover the skillet and cook for 4 to 7 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the shrimp are cooked through. Serve garnished with cilantro.

COOKING TIP: Be sure to keep a close eye on this and other gravy dishes as they cook, making sure to stir and scrape the bottom of the pan regularly to prevent sticking and burning. Depending on the size of your shrimp, the cooking time will vary.

Malabar-Style Prawn Soup

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 25 minutes

This prawn soup is a famous recipe from the Malabar region of Kerala, which is on the southwest coastline between the Western Ghats and the Arabian Sea. Like Fish Molee, this soup is a mild, creamy, and rich combination of fish stock and coconut milk mixed with freshly ground spices. It's a bowl of comfort. **SERVES 4**

2 teaspoons coriander seeds

½ teaspoon peppercorns

½ teaspoon mustard seeds

Pinch fenugreek seeds

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 large onion, sliced

2 green chiles, stemmed and seeded

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and sliced

2 garlic cloves, peeled

1 tablespoon coconut oil

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

3 cups fish stock

8 ounces shrimp, peeled and deveined

1 cup full-fat coconut milk (shake the can before opening and measuring)

2 tablespoons freshly squeezed lime juice

Salt

1. In a dry skillet over medium heat, combine the coriander seeds, peppercorns, mustard seeds, fenugreek seeds, and curry leaves. Toast until the mustard seeds begin to sputter and the

spices are slightly brown, about 1 minute. Remove from the heat and set aside to cool.

2. Transfer the cooled spices to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.
3. In a blender or food processor, combine the onion, green chiles, ginger, and garlic. Process until smooth.
4. In a medium pot over medium-high heat, heat the coconut oil.
5. Add the onion mixture to the skillet and sauté for 2 to 3 minutes, stirring frequently, until it no longer smells raw.
6. Add the spice powder to the onion mixture with the turmeric. Cook for 2 minutes, stirring constantly. If needed, add 1 to 2 tablespoons of water to prevent burning.
7. Add the fish stock and stir well, scraping the bottom of the pot to release any browned bits. Bring the soup to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook for 10 minutes.
8. Add the shrimp to the soup and simmer for 4 to 5 minutes, depending on the size of the shrimp, until cooked through.
9. Pour in the coconut milk and lime juice and heat through. Taste and season with salt, as needed.

SERVING TIP: This creamy soup tastes great served with rice and parathas.

Fish Puttu | Shredded Fish Masala

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 25 minutes

If you are looking for a light meal, this shredded fish masala is for you. The fish is steamed and then shredded and stir-fried with spices. It is more like scrambled fish—hence the name fish puttu. Traditionally, it is prepared with shark, but you can make it with any variety of firm white fish. **SERVES 4**

1 pound boneless, skinless fish fillets
2 tablespoons vegetable oil
½ teaspoon mustard seeds
4 garlic cloves, minced
1 onion, chopped
2 green chiles, finely chopped
2 curry leaf sprigs
2 teaspoons ground coriander
½ teaspoon ground turmeric
1 teaspoon salt
Fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. Place the fish fillets in a steamer basket and place the basket inside a pot filled with 2 inches of water. Cover the pot, place it over medium-high heat, and bring the water to a simmer. Reduce the heat to maintain a simmer and steam the fish for about 10 minutes, until it flakes easily with a fork. Remove the fish from the steamer and flake it into small pieces using a fork. Set aside.

2. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil.
3. Add the mustard seeds and garlic and cook until the mustard seeds begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
4. Add the onion, green chiles, and curry leaves. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onion is transluscent.
5. Stir in the flaked fish, coriander, turmeric, and salt. Cook for 3 to 5 minutes more, stirring frequently to prevent scorching. Serve, garnished with cilantro.

INGREDIENT TIP: Speed up the time it takes to steam the fish by cutting the fillets into a few smaller pieces. When shredding the fish, be sure to remove any small bones missed when it was filleted.

Egg Kurma

CHAPTER 9

Meat Dishes

Though South India is famous for its rice, breakfast, and fish recipes, it is also renowned for its meat recipes. You can find spicy mutton (goat), chicken, pork, and beef dishes. Beef dishes are a favorite in Kerala but not in the other regions and states. Biryanis with chicken or mutton are a filling meal on their own; other curries and gravies are served with rice and flatbreads. Starters like Chicken 65 are always found on restaurant menus. Each state has its traditional way of making these dishes with their own unique blend of spices.

Kodi Vepudu | Andhra Chicken Fry

Prep time: 20 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Kodi vepudu is a spicy and delicious dry chicken curry from Telugu. Kodi *means "chicken," and* vepudu *means "dry curry." You can find this marinated, shallow-fried chicken dish on most restaurant menus. It pairs well with any rice, especially biryani.* **SERVES 4**

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1 pound boneless, skinless chicken breast, cut into 1-inch pieces

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

1 teaspoon red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground coriander

Salt

2 tablespoons vegetable oil

2 large onions, chopped

2 green chiles, slit lengthwise

2 curry leaf sprigs

1 teaspoon garam masala

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

Chopped fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. In a small bowl, combine the chicken, garlic, ginger, chile powder, coriander, and salt. Toss the chicken to coat it in the spices. Let rest while you prepare the rest of the ingredients, or cover and refrigerate for as long as overnight.
2. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat the vegetable oil.

3. Add the onions, green chiles, and curry leaves and mix well. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onions are softened but not browned.
4. Add the chicken and cover the skillet. Cook for 5 to 7 minutes until browned and cooked through, stirring frequently to cook evenly without scorching the spices.
5. Stir in the garam masala and pepper. Cook for 1 minute more. Garnish with cilantro and serve.

COOKING TIP: Be sure to keep the skillet covered while the chicken cooks. The juices from the chicken will cook out and keep the pan moist. Scrape the bottom of the pan every minute or so; otherwise keep the pan covered to prevent the chicken from drying out.

Chicken 65 | Deep-Fried Chicken Dish

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 1 hour to marinate | Cook time: 20 minutes

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Chicken 65 is a classic South Indian dish said to have originated in Chennai, Tamil Nadu. One popular belief is that this dish is made with meat from 65-day-old chickens. Hence—Chicken 65. This spicy deep-fried chicken can be an entrée or a starter. The dish gets its red color from chile powder. **SERVES 4**

---

4 garlic cloves, minced, divided

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

3 teaspoons red chile powder, divided

1 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper, divided

Pinch ground turmeric

1 teaspoon salt

1 pound boneless, skinless chicken breasts or thighs, cubed

½ cup corn flour

Vegetable or corn oil, for frying

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

2 green chiles, sliced

1 curry leaf sprig

¼ cup plain Greek yogurt

1 teaspoon sugar

Red onion slices, for serving

Lemon wedges, for serving

1. In a small bowl, stir together half the garlic, the ginger, 1 teaspoon of chile powder, ½ teaspoon of pepper, the turmeric,

and salt. Add the chicken and mix well to coat it in the spices. Cover and refrigerate for at least 1 hour, or up to overnight.

2. Drain any liquid that has accumulated while the chicken marinated. Sprinkle the corn flour over the chicken and mix well to coat the chicken.
3. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
4. In a large pot over medium-high heat, heat about 1 cup of vegetable oil, or enough to cover the chicken pieces, depending on the size of your pot. The oil is hot enough when a little corn flour sprinkled in sizzles instantly.
5. Working in batches so the chicken is not crowded, carefully lower the chicken pieces into the hot oil. Fry for 7 to 8 minutes per batch, until browned, turning occasionally. Transfer the chicken to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Repeat with the remaining chicken. Set aside.
6. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat 1 tablespoon of vegetable oil.
7. Add the remaining garlic, the cumin seeds, green chiles, and curry leaves. Cook for about 2 minutes, until fragrant and the leaves become crisp.
8. Stir in the yogurt, sugar, and the remaining $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon of pepper and 2 teaspoons of chile powder, mixing well.
9. Add the chicken and stir again. Continue stirring until the water from the yogurt evaporates and the chicken is mostly dry. Serve with red onion slices and lemon wedges for squeezing.

INGREDIENT TIP: The yogurt in this recipe is a necessity, so do not to leave it out. Yogurt gives Chicken 65 its characteristic flavor and texture.

Chicken Dum Biryani

Prep time: 30 minutes, plus 3 hours to marinate | Cook time: 1 hour, 10 minutes

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In traditional dum biryani, the rice and chicken are sealed in a pot and cooked over a slow fire. But here, the biryani is cooked in the oven to achieve the same flavor. This layered dum biryani with basmati rice and marinated chicken locks in loads of moisture; fried onions add crunch.

SERVES 6

---

2 cups basmati rice, rinsed with cool water until the water runs clear

1 (3-inch) cinnamon stick

5 green cardamom pods

5 whole cloves

½ teaspoon peppercorns

1 dried bay leaf

Vegetable or corn oil, for frying

3 onions, sliced

1 whole chicken, cut into pieces

½ cup plain Greek yogurt

2 teaspoons salt, divided

1 teaspoon red chile powder

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

6 cups water

Pinch saffron threads

1 tablespoon boiling water

¼ cup chopped fresh cilantro leaves

2 tablespoons chopped fresh mint

1. Place the rice in a small bowl, cover it with cold water, and let soak for 30 minutes. Drain.
2. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
3. While the rice soaks, in a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder, combine the cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, peppercorns, and bay leaf and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.
4. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat 2 inches of oil until nearly shimmering.
5. Working in batches, add the onions and cook for 6 to 8 minutes until crisp and golden brown. Transfer to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Set aside.
6. In a large bowl, combine the chicken, yogurt, 1 teaspoon of salt, the chile powder, turmeric, and about one-fourth of the fried onions. Add the spice powder and stir well to coat the chicken. Cover the bowl and refrigerate for 3 to 5 hours.
7. In a large pot over high heat, bring the six cups of water to a boil. Season the water with the remaining 1 teaspoon of salt. Pour the drained rice into the boiling water and cook for 5 to 7 minutes until fluffed but still slightly chewy in the middle. Drain in a colander. Set aside.
8. Preheat the oven to 350°F.
9. In a small bowl, crumble the saffron threads into small pieces and add the 1 tablespoon boiling water. Set aside.
10. In a large casserole dish or oven-proof pot, arrange the marinated chicken on the bottom. Sprinkle the cilantro and mint leaves over the chicken. Spread all but ¼ cup of the remaining fried onions over the chicken.
11. Add half the cooked rice on top of the chicken, spreading it evenly across the dish.

12. In a medium bowl, stir together the remaining rice and saffron water. Spread this saffron rice over the plain rice. Top with the remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of fried onions.
13. Cover the dish tightly with aluminum foil and bake for 40 to 50 minutes, until the chicken's juices run clear. Let cool for 5 minutes and serve.

INGREDIENT TIP: Saffron is used in biriyani to give the rice a rich golden hue. If you can't find it locally (or it doesn't fit your budget), use about ½ teaspoon turmeric to color the rice and save a bit on the cost of the saffron in the process.

Ragu Muda Natu Kodi Pulusu | Country Chicken Curry from Andhra

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Free-range, or cage-free, chickens—popularly known as country chickens in India—have a flavor distinct from what Indians refer to as broiler chickens. This curry made with country chickens pairs well with jowar roti or Ragi Mudde—and, of course, rice. Freshly ground spices and lemon juice add a kick to this tangy dish. **SERVES 6**

---

1 whole chicken, skin removed, cut into 10 pieces

1 teaspoon ground turmeric, divided

3 garlic cloves, minced, divided

1 (1-inch) fresh ginger piece, peeled and minced, divided

Juice of ½ lemon

Salt

2 teaspoons coriander seeds

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon whole cloves

½ teaspoon peppercorns

½ teaspoon green cardamom pods

2 large tomatoes, quartered

1 tablespoon vegetable oil

3 green chiles, sliced

1 onion, chopped

2 teaspoons red chile powder

1 cup water

1. In a bowl, combine the chicken, ½ teaspoon of turmeric, half the garlic, and half the ginger. Drizzle the lemon juice over the chicken and mix well. Season with the salt. Set aside.
2. In a pot over medium heat, combine the coriander seeds, cumin seeds, cloves, peppercorns, and cardamom. Dry-roast, stirring continuously, until fragrant. Remove the pan from the heat and transfer the spices to a blender. Add the tomatoes and process until smooth. Set aside.
3. In the same pot over medium-high heat, heat the vegetable oil.
4. Stir in the remaining ½ teaspoon of turmeric, mixing it into the oil.
5. Add the green chiles and cook for 3 to 5 minutes, until they begin to soften.
6. Add the onion and cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until softened.
7. Add the remaining garlic and ginger. Sauté for 1 minute.
8. Add the tomato-spice mixture and cook for 1 minute more.
9. Add the chicken to the pot and stir in the chile powder. Taste and season with more salt as needed. Stir well to combine and add the water. Bring the mixture to a simmer, then cover the pot. Reduce the heat to low and cook for 20 to 25 minutes, until the chicken is done and the juices run clear.

COOKING TIP: If preferred, you can cook the chicken in an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, before adding it to the curry, which can save a little time if you plan it right. To do this, place the marinated chicken and 1 cup of water into the pot. Lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 20 minutes on High Pressure. Once the cooking is done, quick release the pressure. In step 9, add the chicken to the pot and cook for 5 minutes for the flavors to meld, before seasoning with salt.

Mutton Curry

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 30 minutes to marinate | Cook time: 1 hour, 30 minutes

In South India, "mutton" refers to goat meat. It can be difficult to get goat meat in the United States, so in this recipe the mutton curry is made with lamb. The lamb is marinated and flavored with spices, onion, and coconut. The cooking time might sound lengthy, but you can use your electric pressure cooker to reduce it. **SERVES 4**

1 pound boneless lamb, cubed
1 teaspoon ground turmeric
2 teaspoons red chile powder, divided
1 teaspoon salt
1¾ cups water, divided
1 cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)
1 onion, quartered
2 tablespoons vegetable oil
1 onion, chopped
3 garlic cloves, minced
1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced
5 cilantro sprigs, stems and leaves chopped, plus more leaves for garnish
1 tomato, chopped
1½ teaspoons ground coriander
1½ teaspoons garam masala

1. In a large bowl, combine the lamb, turmeric, 1 teaspoon of chile powder, and salt. Toss to coat the lamb in the spices and

let marinate at room temperature for 30 minutes.

2. Place the marinated lamb in a large pot and add 1 cup of water. Place the pot over high heat and bring the water to a boil. Reduce the heat to low, cover the pot, and simmer for about 1 hour until the lamb is tender.
3. In a food processor or blender, combine the coconut, onion quarters, and about ¼ cup of water. Process until a smooth paste forms. Set aside.
4. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil.
5. Add the chopped onion and cook for 4 to 5 minutes until the onion is softened and browned.
6. Add the garlic and ginger and cook for 1 minute.
7. Add the chopped cilantro and cook, stirring, until fragrant.
8. Add the onion-coconut paste and fry for 3 to 4 minutes, until it just begins to brown.
9. Add the lamb and any remaining liquid from the pot and cook for 5 minutes, stirring frequently.
10. Add the tomato, remaining 1 teaspoon of chile powder, the coriander, and garam masala. Cook for 5 minutes more, stirring frequently.
11. Pour about ½ cup of water into the skillet, cover it, and simmer for 10 minutes, stirring frequently, until the curry thickens. Taste and season with salt, as needed. Garnish with cilantro leaves before serving.

COOKING TIP: To cut down on cooking time, complete step 2 in an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®. Place the marinated lamb and 1 cup of water in the pot. Lock the lid in place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 15 minutes on High Pressure. Once the cooking is complete, let

the pressure release naturally. When ready, carefully unlock and remove the lid and add the lamb to the pot in step 9.

Egg Kurma | Egg Curry

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Jazz up hardboiled eggs by simmering them in this delicious coconut-based gravy. In this South Indian version of kurma, the coconut adds creaminess. The kurma base is very versatile; you can replace the egg with cooked lamb or chicken or keep it vegetarian by adding steamed vegetables. **SERVES 4**

1 teaspoon fennel seeds

1 teaspoon white poppy seeds

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

2 green cardamom pods

2 whole cloves

2 tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

5 or 6 whole cashews

1 tablespoon vegetable oil

2 onions, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

1 curry leaf sprig

1 teaspoon red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground coriander

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

Salt

1 tomato, chopped

4 hardboiled eggs, peeled

2 cups water

Chopped fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, combine the fennel seeds, poppy seeds, cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, coconut, and cashews. Dry-roast for 2 to 3 minutes until fragrant. Remove from the heat and let cool.
2. Transfer the spices, coconut, and cashews to a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder and grind into a fine powder. Set aside.
3. In a large pot over medium-high heat, heat the vegetable oil.
4. Add the onions and cook for 5 to 6 minutes, until softened.
5. Add the garlic and ginger and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, stirring constantly.
6. Stir in the curry leaves, chile powder, coriander, and turmeric. Season with salt.
7. Add the tomato and cook for 3 to 5 minutes, until softened.
8. Add the spice powder and cook for 3 to 4 minutes, stirring constantly, taking care not to scorch the spices.
9. Add the eggs and stir to combine. Pour in the water and stir to mix. Bring the liquid to a simmer, reduce the heat to maintain a simmer, and cook for 5 to 7 minutes until the gravy thickens. Garnish with chopped cilantro leaves.

SERVING TIP: Egg Kurma pairs really well with Chicken Dum Biryani, or serve it with parotta or chapati.

Hyderabadi-Style Kheema | Hyderabadi-Style Minced Meat

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 40 minutes

Hyderabadi cuisine has a heavy Mughlai influence. Kheema*, or minced mutton (lamb or goat meat), is a common staple in the Hyderabadi kitchen. This Hyderabadi-style gravy kheema is a simple curry made with ground lamb. It's quick to make because no marinating is required.* **SERVES 4**

---

2 tablespoons vegetable oil

4 green cardamom pods

3 peppercorns

2 whole cloves

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

2 onions, finely chopped

4 garlic cloves, finely minced

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and finely minced

1 large tomato, chopped

1 pound ground lamb

1 teaspoon ground turmeric

1 teaspoon red chile powder

Salt

½ cup water

1 teaspoon garam masala

1 green chile, chopped

Juice of ½ lemon

Chopped fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil. Add the cardamom, peppercorns, cloves, and cinnamon and cook for 1 to 2 minutes, stirring constantly, until fragrant.
2. Add the onions and cook for 5 to 7 minutes, until softened and browned.
3. Add the garlic and ginger and cook for about 2 minutes, stirring frequently.
4. Add the tomato and cook for 2 to 3 minutes more, until softened.
5. Increase the heat to medium-high and add the ground lamb. Fry for about 1 minute, breaking the meat into small pieces.
6. Add the turmeric and chile powder. Season with salt. Continue cooking for 3 to 4 minutes more, until the ground lamb is cooked through.
7. Add the water, cover the skillet, reduce the heat to low, and simmer for 20 minutes.
8. Turn off the heat and stir in the garam masala and green chile. Re-cover the skillet and let the mixture steam for 2 minutes. Serve, sprinkled with lemon juice and cilantro leaves.

SERVING TIP: Serve kheema with any Indian bread or rice. If desired, you can also add hardboiled egg as a garnish. Cut one egg into wedges and serve alongside the kheema.

Kori Gassi | Mangalorean Chicken Curry

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 35 minutes

Kori gassi is the signature dish of the Tulu-speaking Bunt community from Karnataka. It is a spicy, tangy Mangalorean-style chicken curry made rich and creamy by coconut and coconut milk, which counter the heat from the chiles. With freshly ground spices, this flavorful chicken curry pairs well with Neer Dosa, idiyappam, and plain steamed rice.
SERVES 4

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3 tablespoons dried, unsweetened coconut

3 tablespoons boiling water

1 tablespoon seedless tamarind block soaked in ¼ cup boiling water for 30 minutes

4 tablespoons coconut oil, divided

1 teaspoon mustard seeds

3 tablespoons coriander seeds

½ teaspoon fennel seeds

½ teaspoon cumin seeds

½ teaspoon peppercorns

Pinch ground fenugreek

5 or 6 dried Guntur chiles

6 garlic cloves, minced

1 onion, chopped

¾ cup water, divided

Handful curry leaves

1 large red onion, thinly sliced

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

1 pound boneless, skinless chicken breast, cut into small pieces

2 tomatoes, chopped

¾ cup full-fat coconut milk

1 teaspoon salt

1. In a small bowl, combine the coconut and boiling water. Set aside to soak.
2. Stir the tamarind and the water it has been soaking in. Using your fingers, remove the tamarind flesh and squeeze the juice from the pods, removing any fibers and membranes as well. Pour the mixture into a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl and use a spoon to press as much of the pulp as possible through the strainer. Set the tamarind pulp aside.
3. In a skillet over medium heat, heat 2 tablespoons of coconut oil.
4. Add the mustard seeds and cook until they begin to sputter, about 1 minute.
5. Add the coriander seeds, fennel seeds, cumin seeds, peppercorns, and fenugreek. Sauté until fragrant, about 30 seconds.
6. Add the Guntur chiles to the skillet and stir-fry for 3 to 4 minutes, until they are slightly browned.
7. Drain any remaining water from the coconut and add it to the skillet along with the garlic and chopped onion. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes, until the onion is softened. Transfer the mixture to a bowl and set aside to cool. Once cool, transfer to a blender or food processor, add ½ cup of water, and process until a smooth paste forms.
8. In a wide pot over medium heat, heat the remaining 2 tablespoons of coconut oil.
9. Add the curry leaves and fry briefly.

10. Add the red onion and turmeric and cook for 5 to 7 minutes, until the onion is browned.
11. Add the chicken. Cook for 3 to 4 minutes, until golden and nearly cooked through, stirring continuously.
12. Add the tomatoes and cook for 1 to 2 minutes, stirring frequently.
13. Add the onion-spice paste and stir well to mix. Use the remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ cup of water to rinse out the blender jar and add this to the pot as well.
14. Stir in the tamarind pulp and coconut milk and bring the curry to a simmer. Remove the pot from the heat and season with the salt.

COOKING TIP: If needed, add a little more hot water to the curry to loosen it if it is too thick.

Beef Ularthiyathu | Slow-Roasted Beef

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 55 minutes

*Beef is not a typical ingredient in most Indian kitchens, but it's a star ingredient in the Kerala region. You can find tender, spiced beef ularthiyathu (*ularthiyathu *means "roasted" in Malayalam) in star-rated hotels and street-side food joints alike.* **SERVES 8**

2 pounds beef chuck, or round roast or steak, cut into 1 inch cubes

1 teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

½ teaspoon ground turmeric

½ cup water

2 tablespoons plus 1 teaspoon coconut oil, divided

2 curry leaf sprigs, divided

2 onions, sliced

3 green chiles, minced

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 (½-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

1 teaspoon red chile powder

1 teaspoon ground coriander

1 teaspoon garam masala

2 tablespoons dried coconut flakes, or slices

1. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the beef, salt, pepper, and turmeric. Mix well and add the water.

2. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 15 minutes on High Pressure. Once the cooking is complete, let the pressure release naturally for 10 minutes, then quick release any remaining pressure.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 2 times. When the cooking is done, let the pressure release naturally for 10 minutes, then quick release any remaining pressure.
3. While the beef cooks, in a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat 2 tablespoons of coconut oil.
4. Add half the curry leaves, the onions, and green chiles to the skillet and mix well. Cook for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring frequently, until the onions are softened.
5. Add the garlic and ginger and cook for 1 minute, stirring constantly.
6. Stir in the chile powder, coriander, and garam masala. Reduce the heat to low.
7. When the meat is ready, carefully unlock and remove the lid of the pressure cooker. Transfer the meat and any juices in the pot to the skillet. Stir well and bring the mixture to a simmer. Cook the meat until any liquid dries out, about 5 minutes, stirring occasionally to prevent scorching.
8. Meanwhile, in a small skillet over medium heat, heat the remaining 1 teaspoon of coconut oil.
9. Add the dried coconut and cook for about 3 minutes, stirring frequently, until browned.

10. Add the remaining curry leaves and cook, stirring well, until the leaves are browned. Remove from the heat and set aside.
11. Once the liquid has boiled out of the skillet with the beef, continue cooking for a few minutes more, stirring constantly, until the meat is completely dried out. Add the browned curry leaves and coconut and stir to combine.

INGREDIENT TIP: Coconut oil is used in many recipes from Kerala and imparts a distinctive coconut flavor. If you don't have any on hand, vegetable oil can be substituted.

Mutton Kola Urundai | Mutton Meat Balls

Prep time: 15 minutes | Cook time: 15 minutes

Mutton kola urundai is the South Indian version of meatballs made with ground lamb. Kola urundai *means "round balls," and there are many varieties. This version is quite famous around the Madurai and Chettinadu regions of Tamil Nadu. Ground spices and chiles give these meatballs a great burst of flavor. You can serve them as a snack or as part of a meal with biryani.* **SERVES 4**

1 pound ground lamb

½ cup roasted split chickpeas

1 teaspoon fennel seeds

1 teaspoon cumin seeds

1 teaspoon peppercorns

1 (1-inch) cinnamon stick

1 whole clove

2 green cardamom pods

1 teaspoon ground turmeric

1 teaspoon red chile powder

1 teaspoon salt

1 onion, quartered

1 green chile, stemmed and seeded

Handful curry leaves

¼ cup chopped fresh cilantro

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

4 garlic cloves, coarsely chopped

1 (1-inch) piece fresh ginger, peeled and coarsely chopped

Vegetable or corn oil, for greasing hands and frying

1. In a large skillet over medium heat, cook the ground lamb for 6 to 8 minutes, until browned, breaking it up into smaller pieces with a spoon. Drain and set aside to cool.
2. While the meat cooks, in a spice grinder or clean coffee grinder, grind the roasted split chickpeas into a fine powder. Add the fennel seeds, cumin seeds, peppercorns, cinnamon, clove, and cardamom and grind into a fine powder. Transfer the spice mix to a small bowl and stir in the turmeric, chile powder, and salt. Set aside.
3. In a blender or food processor, combine the onion, green chile, and curry leaves. Pulse until they're coarsely ground. Add the cooked lamb, cilantro, coconut, garlic, and ginger and process until mixed. Transfer the mixture to a large bowl.
4. Add the roasted split chickpea-spice mixture and mix well to combine.
5. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
6. Coat your hands with a little oil to prevent sticking and form the mixture into small 1½-inch balls, pressing them firmly with your hands to form.
7. In a large pot over medium heat, heat 2 inches of vegetable oil until it shimmers.
8. Carefully add the meatballs to the hot oil in a single layer. Fry them for 2 to 3 minutes, on all sides, flipping until golden brown all around. Transfer the cooked meatballs to the paper towel–lined plate to drain.

COOKING TIP: When you grind the onion, chile, and curry leaves in step 3, process until they are uniformly ground. You don't want any large pieces in the final mixture, as they will break away during frying and can cause the meatballs to fall apart.

Tapioca Pearls Pudding

CHAPTER 10

Sweets

Sweets are part and parcel of South Indian cuisine. For every festival, we prepare a variety of different sweet recipes. Though payasam, or pudding, finds its place in all the festival feasts, many more sweets are also served. Traditional feasts celebrated throughout the year are incomplete without at least two sweet options. Most sweets are prepared using ghee, which adds richness and creaminess. The list of recipe steps might seem lengthy, but some steps can be done simultaneously.

Unni Appam | Sweet Banana Fritters

Prep time: 15 minutes, plus 15 minutes rest time | Cook time: 10 minutes

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Unni *("small")* appam *("rice cakes") in Malayalam, or* Nei appam*, is a classic sweet made mainly in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. It's a flour-based sweet fritter with banana fried in oil. It is very similar to the Dutch* aebleskiver. **SERVES 6**

½ cup water

1 cup powdered jaggery

¼ cup all-purpose flour

¼ cup rice flour

¼ cup whole-wheat flour

⅛ teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon baking soda

½ teaspoon ground cardamom

2 teaspoons sesame seeds, toasted

2 tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 banana, puréed

½ cup vegetable or corn oil

Melted ghee, for drizzling

1. In a saucepan over medium heat, bring the water and jaggery to a simmer. When the jaggery melts, turn off the heat. Strain the jaggery water through a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl to remove any impurities.

2. In a medium bowl, whisk the all-purpose flour, rice flour, whole-wheat flour, salt, baking soda, cardamom, sesame seeds, and coconut.
3. Whisk in the puréed banana.
4. While whisking, slowly pour in the jaggery water, until it forms a smooth, pourable, lump-free batter. Let the batter rest for 15 minutes.
5. Line a plate with paper towels and set aside.
6. Place an appe or paniyaram pan over medium-high heat until hot.
7. Reduce the heat to medium and add 1 teaspoon of oil to each mold. Fill each mold three-quarters full with batter. Cook for 1 to 1½ minutes. Using a knife or fork, carefully flip the appams. Cook for 45 seconds to 1 minute more. Remove them from the pan and place on the paper towel–lined plate. Repeat with the remaining appams.
8. Drizzle the finished appams with melted ghee, about ¼ teaspoon each, and serve hot.

COOKING TIP: Along with ground cardamom, you can also add ½ teaspoon ground ginger for enhanced flavor.

Ada Pradhaman | Vegan Rice Flakes Pudding

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

A vegan and gluten-free kheer, or pudding, from Kerala, this pudding is made with rice flakes (popularly known as rice ada*), jaggery, and coconut milk. The vegetarian version, made with whole cow's milk, is known as* palada*. Both ada pradhaman and palada are popular festival sweets. Here is my simple vegan version using store-bought rice ada.*
SERVES 4

2½ cups water, divided

½ cup rice flakes

¾ cup powdered jaggery

2 cups full-fat coconut milk

2 green cardamom pods, crushed

1. In a medium saucepan over high heat, bring 2 cups of water to boil, then turn off the heat.
2. Add the rice flakes, cover the pan, and let sit for 10 to 12 minutes. Drain the rice flakes in a fine-mesh strainer and rinse them under cold water. Transfer the rice flakes to a bowl and set aside.
3. Wipe out the saucepan and return it to medium heat. In the pan, combine the remaining ½ cup of water and jaggery. Bring the mixture to a simmer. When the jaggery melts, turn off the heat. Strain the jaggery water through a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl to remove any impurities.

4. Return the saucepan to the heat and add the jaggery water, coconut milk, and cardamom. Simmer for 5 to 7 minutes.
5. Stir in the rice flakes and simmer for 4 to 5 minutes. Turn off the heat. Serve warm.

COOKING TIP: For a vegetarian version, replace the coconut milk with whole milk, and heat some raisins and cashews in 2 teaspoons of ghee before adding them to the kheer.

Saggubiyyam Payasam | Tapioca Pearls Pudding

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 2 hours to soak | Cook time: 20 minutes

This dish is quite popular across South India. In Telugu, it is known as saggubiyyam, and in Tamil it is known as javvarisi. *It's rich and creamy and this recipe is very versatile (see the Substitution Tip).*
SERVES 6

½ cup tapioca pearls, rinsed twice with cold water, drained

4 cups reduced-fat milk

¼ cup condensed milk

¾ cup sugar

1 teaspoon ground cardamom

2 teaspoons ghee

10 raisins

10 cashews

1. In a large bowl, combine the tapioca with enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 2 hours. Drain.
2. In a heavy-bottom medium saucepan over medium heat, bring the reduced-fat milk just to a boil. Just as small bubbles start to form in the milk, stir in the tapioca. Reduce the heat to low and cook the tapioca for 7 to 8 minutes, stirring every 2 to 3 minutes, until soft and shiny.
3. Stir in the condensed milk, sugar, and cardamom. Cook for about 5 minutes, until the sugar is dissolved.
4. In a small skillet over medium heat, melt the ghee.

5. Add the raisins and cashews. Roast for about 1 minute until they are browned. Stir them into the pudding. Serve warm.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of tapioca pearls, use vermicelli pieces, beaten rice flakes, or cooked rice. Vermicelli and beaten rice flakes don't need to be soaked first.

Rava Kesari | Thick Semolina Pudding

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 20 minutes

Kesari*, or semolina pudding, is quite popular in India. In the North, it is called* sheera*, and in the South it is called kesari. In restaurants, it is served with rava upma or khara bath. The khara bath and kesari bath combo are known as the chow-chow bath.* **SERVES 8**

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2 cups water

4 teaspoons ghee, divided

2 cups sugar

⅛ teaspoon pineapple extract

⅛ teaspoon edible orange food coloring

1 cup roasted semolina

10 cashews

10 raisins

1. In a medium saucepan over medium heat, combine the water and 1 teaspoon of ghee. Cook for 4 to 5 minutes, until small bubbles start to form. Add the sugar and cook for about 2 minutes, until the sugar dissolves. Add the pineapple extract and food coloring and bring the mixture to a rolling boil. Boil the sugar syrup for 3 minutes.
2. Stirring constantly, slowly add the roasted semolina to the sugar syrup.
3. Stir in 2 teaspoons of ghee and cook for 4 to 5 minutes, stirring constantly, until all the moisture is absorbed. Turn off the heat.

4. In a small skillet over medium heat, melt the remaining 1 teaspoon of ghee.
5. Add the cashews and raisins and cook for about 1 minute, until the cashews are golden brown. Stir them into the kesari. Serve warm.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of pineapple, add any fruit flavor you like, or omit it and add ground cardamom.

Obbattu | Stuffed Sweet Flatbread with Bengal Gram

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 30 to 45 minutes rest time | Cook time: 45 minutes

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This stuffed sweet flatbread is a must with any Telugu and Kannada New Year's feast. Popularly known as holige *or obbattu in Kannada,* bobbatlu *in Telugu, and* boli *in Tamil, this sweet bread can be prepared with different stuffings. This recipe stuffs the flatbread with Bengal gram, jaggery, and coconut.* **MAKES 6**

FOR THE DOUGH

½ cup all-purpose flour, plus more for dusting

¼ teaspoon ground turmeric

⅛ teaspoon salt

⅛ teaspoon baking soda

¼ cup water

2 tablespoons sesame oil

FOR THE STUFFING

10 teaspoons ghee, divided, plus more for serving

¼ cup Bengal gram, rinsed well and drained

1 cups water

½ cup powdered jaggery

¼ teaspoon ground cardamom

¼ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature) (optional)

Vegetable or corn oil, for greasing

TO MAKE THE DOUGH

In a medium bowl, stir together the flour, turmeric, salt, and baking soda.

While stirring, slowly add the water to form a smooth dough. Stir in the sesame oil. Let the dough rest for 30 to 45 minutes, or up to 2 hours.

TO MAKE THE STUFFING

1. While the dough rests, prepare the stuffing. In a medium skillet over medium heat, melt 1 teaspoon of ghee.
2. Add the Bengal gram and roast for about 3 minutes, until it turns light brown. Remove from the heat and let cool.
3. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or a stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the cooled Bengal gram and water.
4. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 8 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 2 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
5. Carefully unlock and remove the lid and drain the Bengal gram. Let cool. Transfer it to a blender and add the jaggery, cardamom, and coconut (if using). Process until a smooth paste forms.
6. In a medium skillet over medium heat, melt 3 teaspoons of ghee.

7. Add the ground Bengal gram paste and cook for about 5 minutes until all the moisture is absorbed. Turn off the heat. When cool enough to handle, but still warm, form the stuffing mixture into six small lime-size balls. Set aside.
8. Pinch off a lemon-size piece of dough and flatten it into a 2-inch circle. Place 1 stuffing ball in the center and wrap the dough around it. Gently roll this into a smooth ball. Dust a rolling pin and clean work surface with flour. Roll the stuffed dough into a 4-inch circle. Repeat this step with the remaining dough and stuffing.
9. Heat a griddle over medium heat.
10. Carefully place a flatbread on the griddle and cook for 45 seconds. Flip the flatbread and spread 1 teaspoon of ghee around the edges of the dough. Cook for 45 seconds. The bread will puff up slightly. When you see small brown spots, remove the bread from the griddle. Repeat this step with the remaining flatbreads and ghee.
11. Serve the obbattu warm with a dollop of ghee.

SUBSTITUTION TIP: Instead of Bengal gram, use split pigeon peas. Traditionally all-purpose flour is used for this flatbread, but you can use half whole-wheat flour and half all-purpose flour. This recipe does need flour with gluten.

Poornam Boorelu | Stuffed Sweet Fritters

Prep time: 10 minutes, plus 2 hours to soak | Cook time: 45 minutes

Poornam boorelu *from Andhra and Telangana is a traditional sweet for weddings and other celebrations. Like Obbattu, the stuffing uses Bengal gram. This recipe features a rice and black lentil batter.* **MAKES 16**

FOR THE BATTER

1 cup sona masoori rice, rinsed with cool water, drained

½ cup husked whole black lentils, rinsed with cool water, drained

½ to 1 cup water

½ teaspoon salt

FOR THE STUFFING

6 teaspoons ghee, plus more for serving

½ cup Bengal gram, rinsed and drained

1½ cups water

1 cup powdered jaggery

½ teaspoon ground cardamom

½ cup shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

1 cup vegetable or corn oil

TO MAKE THE BATTER

1. In a medium bowl, combine the rice, black lentils, and enough cold water to cover by 2 to 3 inches. Let soak at room temperature for 2 hours. Drain.

2. In a blender, combine the drained rice and black lentils and ½ cup of water. Process until a smooth, thick batter forms. If it is too thick, add more water to get the right consistency—thick, smooth, and pourable, like idli batter. Add the salt and pulse to combine. Set aside.

TO MAKE THE STUFFING

1. In a medium skillet over medium heat, melt 1 teaspoon of ghee.
2. Add the Bengal gram and roast for about 3 minutes until it turns light brown. Remove from the heat and let cool.
3. In an electric pressure cooker, such as the Instant Pot®, or stovetop pressure cooker or pressure pan, combine the cooled Bengal gram and water.
4. For an electric pressure cooker, lock the lid into place and make sure the valve is in the Sealed position. Select Pressure Cook or Manual and set the time to 8 minutes on High Pressure. Let the pressure release naturally.

   For a stovetop pressure cooker, place it over medium heat and place the lid on. Ensure the sealing ring is on and place the weight on. Pressure cook until the cooker "whistles" 2 times. Let the pressure release naturally.
5. Carefully unlock and remove the lid and drain the Bengal gram. Let cool.
6. In a blender, combine the Bengal gram, jaggery, cardamom, and coconut. Process until a smooth paste forms. Set aside.
7. Wipe out the skillet and return it to medium heat. Add 5 teaspoons of ghee to melt.

8. Add the ground Bengal gram paste and cook for about 5 minutes until all the moisture is absorbed. Turn off the heat. When cool enough to handle, but still warm, form the mixture into 16 small lime-size stuffing balls.
9. Line a plate with paper towel and set aside.
10. In a large skillet over medium heat, heat the vegetable oil to between 350°F and 375°F. Test to see if the oil is hot enough by dropping 1 teaspoon of batter into the hot oil. If it sizzles and floats, without sinking, the oil is ready for frying.
11. Working in batches of about four at a time, dip the stuffing balls into the batter, making sure they are well covered.
12. Carefully drop the battered balls into the hot oil. Fry for 1 minute. Using a slotted spoon, slowly and carefully flip the fritters. Cook for 1 minute more, or until the bubbling sound stops. Use the spoon to transfer the fritters to the paper towel–lined plate to drain. Dip another batch of stuffing balls into the batter and continue frying. Serve with a dollop of ghee.

COOKING TIP: You can also use fresh, nonfermented Idli/Dosai batter to make this sweet. The remaining batter can be used to make Punugulu.

Gasagase Payasa | Poppy Seed Kheer

Prep time: 10 minutes | Cook time: 30 minutes

Gasagase *means "poppy seeds" in Kannada and* payasa *means "pudding." This popular gluten-free Karnataka sweet contains poppy seeds, coconut, and jaggery. Poppy seeds are known as a natural coolant that soothes the body.* **SERVES 6**

---

3 tablespoons poppy seeds

1 tablespoon rice, any variety

3 tablespoons shredded fresh coconut (or frozen, thawed to room temperature)

3 cups water, divided

1 cup powdered jaggery

¼ teaspoon ground cardamom

1 teaspoon ghee

5 cashews

5 raisins

1. Heat a small skillet over medium heat. Add the poppy seeds and rice and dry-roast for 3 to 4 minutes, until aromatic. Turn off the heat and stir in the coconut. Let cool. Transfer the mixture to a blender, add ½ cup of water, and blend until coarsely ground.
2. Place a medium saucepan over medium heat and add the remaining 2½ cups of water and the jaggery. Cook until the jaggery dissolves. Strain the jaggery water through a fine-mesh strainer set over a bowl to remove any impurities. Return the jaggery water to the pan and place it back over medium heat.

Stir in the cardamom. Simmer for 5 minutes. Stir in the ground poppy seed mix and simmer for 5 minutes.

3. In a small skillet over medium heat, melt the ghee.
4. Add the cashews and raisins. Roast for about 1 minute, until the cashews turn brown. Turn off the heat and stir them into the pudding. Cool for several minutes, and serve warm.

COOKING TIP: Along with poppy seeds and rice, you can roast 3 to 4 almonds and grind them with the other ingredients for a rich, creamy version.

Measurement Conversions

	US STANDARD	US STANDARD (OUNCES)	METRIC (APPROXIMATE)
VOLUME EQUIVALENTS (LIQUID)	2 tablespoons	1 fl. oz.	30 mL
	¼ cup	2 fl. oz.	60 mL
	½ cup	4 fl. oz.	120 mL
	1 cup	8 fl. oz.	240 mL
	1 ½ cups	12 fl. oz.	355 mL
	2 cups or 1 pint	16 fl. oz.	475 mL
	4 cups or 1 quart	32 fl. oz.	1 L
	1 gallon	128 fl. oz.	4 L
VOLUME EQUIVALENTS (DRY)	⅛ teaspoon	_____	0.5 mL
	¼ teaspoon	_____	1 mL
	½ teaspoon	_____	2 mL
	¾ teaspoon	_____	4 mL
	1 teaspoon	_____	5 mL
	1 tablespoon	_____	15 mL
	¼ cup	_____	59 mL
	⅓ cup	_____	79 mL
	½ cup	_____	118 mL
	⅔ cup	_____	156 mL
	¾ cup	_____	177 mL

	1 cup	_____	235 mL
	2 cups or 1 pint	_____	475 mL
	3 cups	_____	700 mL
	4 cups or 1 quart	_____	1 L
	½ gallon	_____	2 L
	1 gallon	_____	4 L
WEIGHT EQUIVALENTS	½ ounce	_____	15 g
	1 ounce	_____	30 g
	2 ounces	_____	60 g
	4 ounces		115 g
	8 ounces	_____	225 g
	12 ounces	_____	340 g
	16 ounces or 1 pound	_____	455 g

	FAHRENHEIT (F)	CELSIUS (C) (APPROXIMATE)
OVEN TEMPERATURES	250°F	120°F
	300°F	150°C
	325°F	180°C
	375°F	190°C
	400°F	200°C
	425°F	220°C
	450°F	230°C

Acknowledgments

First, I would like to thank God Almighty for giving me this fantastic opportunity to write about South Indian food.

To Callisto Media, for believing in me and providing this opportunity after writing *Instant Pot® Vegetarian Cookbook*. I never thought I would write two cookbooks in the same year! I want to thank Katherine Green for taking care of the non-vegetarian recipes. I also want to thank the Callisto Media editorial team for helping me with all the edits.

To my dad; his loving memory has guided me throughout this endeavor.

To my mom, my Guru, who introduced and taught me the art of cooking and for teaching me all the traditional recipes.

To my husband, my pillar of strength. Thank you for the unconditional love and support throughout this book journey.

To my son and fur child, for being so supportive and adjusting their schedules for me.

To my cousins Sivakumar and Neeraja for pitching in and sharing all their information about South Indian cooking.

To my friends Neena, Sreelatha, and Srinivas for their expert guidance with Kerala, Andhra, and Telangana recipes.

Last, but not least, I would like to thank all my friends, family, and readers for your continuous encouragement and support.

About the Author

Srividhya Gopalakrishnan is a software engineer and passionate home cook and food blogger. She is the author of the *Instant Pot® Vegetarian Cookbook*. As much as she loves to develop websites, she is also passionate about discovering new recipes, exploring traditional foods, and researching ingredients. She started her blog vidhyashomecooking.com in 2009 to share her family recipes and record and revive an interest in authentic Indian food. Her blog contains more than 900 vegetarian and vegan recipes, which include not only traditional Indian foods but also kid-friendly fusion food, eggless bakes, and Instant Pot® recipes from around the world. When she is not coding, cooking, clicking, and running after kids, she loves to read. She lives in the Bay Area of California with her husband, son, and four-legged fur child.

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